

Constitution Museum Project

Art Related Research

Artist Profiles



Nandalal Bose

Chief artist, head of Kala Bhavana (Santiniketan); supervised and guided the entire illustration project.

Nandalal Bose (1882–1966) occupies a central position in the history of modern Indian art, not only as a pioneer of the Bengal School but also as a visionary who helped shape the cultural identity of a newly emerging nation. Trained under Abanindranath Tagore, Bose was deeply influenced by the aesthetics of Ajanta murals and the ideals of contextual modernism, which sought to root artistic practice in indigenous traditions while engaging with global modernist thought. His art often depicted themes from Indian mythology, folk traditions, and rural life, reflecting his conviction that India's creative future lay in reviving its classical and vernacular traditions rather than imitating Western models. His famous black-and-white linocut of Mahatma Gandhi during the Dandi March (1930) became an emblem of resistance and non-violence, showing how art could serve as both cultural expression and political statement. As the principal of Kala Bhavana at Santiniketan from 1921, Bose played a foundational role in building Visva-Bharati into a hub of creative and intellectual exchange, mentoring generations of artists such as Ramkinkar Baij, Benode Behari Mukherjee, and Satyajit Ray. In him, pedagogy and practice fused seamlessly, making him both a guide and an innovator.

Beyond his artistic achievements, Bose's contribution to the symbolic imagination of modern India was profound. At the request of Jawaharlal Nehru, he sketched national emblems, including those for the Bharat Ratna and Padma awards, and perhaps most memorably, he and his students were entrusted with the task of illustrating the original manuscript of the Constitution of India. This monumental project wove together motifs from India's civilizational heritage, ranging from the Vedic period and Mauryan art to Mughal miniatures and the freedom struggle, embodying the Constitution's vision of unity in

diversity. In recognition of his role as both an artist and cultural architect, Bose received some of the nation's highest honours, including the Padma Vibhushan (1954), the title of Deshikottama from Visva-Bharati, and an honorary D.Litt. from the University of Calcutta. His body of work, now preserved in collections such as the National Gallery of Modern Art, testifies not only to his individual genius but also to a larger project of reimagining India's art as inseparable from its history, spirituality, and politics. Bose was not simply an artist in the conventional sense; he was a bridge between tradition and modernity, between India's past and its aspirations for the future. In this sense, his legacy continues to inform how Indian art is seen, studied, and practised today.



Beohar Rammanohar Sinha

Principal artist under Bose; executed many full-page illustrations and motifs.

Beohar Rammanohar Sinha (1929–2007) was a distinguished painter and muralist whose legacy is most vividly tied to his work on the original manuscript of the Indian Constitution. A student of Nandalal Bose at Santiniketan, he absorbed the ideals of contextual modernism, blending classical Indian traditions with contemporary sensibilities. Under Bose's leadership, Sinha illustrated many of the ornate borders and full-page drawings in the Constitution, most notably the entire Preamble page, which remains one of the document's most iconic visual statements. His motifs drew inspiration from Ajanta, Ellora, Sanchi, and other historic sites, transforming the Constitution into not just a legal charter but a cultural artefact embodying India's civilizational depth. Initially hesitant to claim authorship, he was persuaded by Bose to sign his illustrations, ensuring that his contributions would be recognised for posterity. This act places him at the intersection of art and nation-making, where the visual served to strengthen the symbolic authority of independent India's founding text.

Beyond the Constitution, Sinha's artistic career reflected a deep engagement with both national history and international cultural dialogue. He created large-scale murals and frescoes in Jabalpur, Santiniketan, and elsewhere, often centred on nationalist figures such as Rani Durgavati and Subhas Chandra Bose, which carried his conviction that art should speak to collective memory and pride. His Gandhian upbringing in Jabalpur imbued his work with a moral and political seriousness that harmonised with his

training at Santiniketan, resulting in a style that was at once rooted and experimental. In the 1950s, he represented India in cultural exchanges with China and other parts of Asia, collaborating with artists like Qi Baishi and Li Keran, and adapting elements of Zen and Shui-mo techniques into his own practice. These cross-cultural ventures expanded his artistic vocabulary and demonstrated how Indian art could act as a vehicle of diplomacy. Today, Sinha is remembered not only as one of the key contributors to the Constitution's visual grandeur but also as an artist who wove together heritage, nationalism, and internationalism, leaving behind a legacy that linked art to the aspirations of a newly independent nation.



Dinanath Bhargava

Designed the national emblem (Lion Capital of Ashoka) that appears in the Constitution.

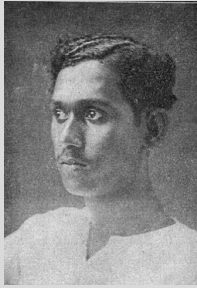
Dinanath Bhargava (1927–2016) was a student of Nandalal Bose at Santiniketan and one of the youngest artists entrusted with illustrating the original manuscript of the Indian Constitution. At just 21, he was given the task of designing the opening page, for which he drew the national emblem of the Lion Capital of Ashoka, now one of India's most enduring symbols. Bhargava's work combined a meticulous attention to detail with a deep grounding in classical Indian art traditions, evident in the fine line work and naturalistic motifs of flora and fauna that frame the Constitution's pages. Beyond this historic contribution, he went on to establish himself as a painter and designer, known for his studies of nature, especially plants and birds, which he approached with both scientific precision and artistic sensitivity. His early role in shaping the Constitution's visual identity and his lifelong commitment to Indian aesthetics mark him as an important, though often understated, figure in the story of modern Indian art.

Vinayak Sivaram Masoji

Assisted with borders, motifs, and illustrations.

Vinayak Sivaram Masoji (1916–1997) was among the group of artists from Santiniketan chosen by Nandalal Bose to contribute illustrations to the original manuscript of the Indian Constitution. A

contemporary of Beohar Rammanohar Sinha and Dinanath Bhargava, Masoji was tasked with executing decorative borders and motifs that drew upon India's rich classical and folk traditions, helping transform the Constitution into a visual archive of the nation's cultural heritage. His training at Kala Bhavana equipped him with a strong foundation in contextual modernism, and his work for the Constitution reflects this synthesis of revivalist aesthetics and modern sensibilities. Though less widely celebrated than some of his peers, Masoji's role was integral in the collective effort that gave the Constitution its unique visual identity. Beyond this project, he continued to practice as a painter and educator, remembered for his refined draughtsmanship and his commitment to linking art with the ideals of national identity and cultural continuity.



Biswarup Bose

Worked on decorative elements and embellishments.

Biswarup (sometimes spelt Biswaroop/Biswarup) Bose — son of Nandalal Bose — was a key figure in Santiniketan's printmaking lineage: a skilled woodcut and print artist who helped sustain and teach the craft at Kala Bhavana. Trained in Japan at his father's encouragement to learn coloured woodcut techniques, he returned to Santiniketan and became an effective teacher for the printmaking section, passing those techniques to the next generation. He also acted as a steward of his father's estate: museum provenance records show works passing from Nandalal Bose to Biswarup and later entering institutional collections, which confirms his role as both inheritor and preserver of that artistic archive. While not always named front-and-centre like Nandalal or some contemporaries, Biswarup appears in catalogues and exhibition histories connected to the Santiniketan circle (and is listed among artists associated with projects around that milieu), and his family — including his wife Nibedita — feature in accounts of the group that ornamented the Constitution and related commissions. In short, Biswarup's significance is practical and institutional: he broadened Santiniketan's printmaking practice, taught techniques learned abroad, and preserved a body of work that helped anchor the visual legacy of Nandalal Bose and his school.

A. Perumal

Illustrator, contributed to borders and miniature-style motifs.

A. Perumal (1915–2004), fondly known as “Perumalda,” was born in Ammapatti, a village near Uthamapalayam in Tamil Nadu, and later moved to Santiniketan, where he trained at Kala Bhavana under Nandalal Bose and Benode Behari Mukherjee. His practice spanned watercolours, tempera, sculptures, wood, and ceramic tile murals, carrying forward the Bengal School’s ideals of naturalism, folk motifs, and the integration of art with daily life. Among his most significant contributions was his work on the *Constitution of India* manuscript, where he illustrated a border for Part 19 (“Miscellaneous”), notably the page depicting Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose saluting in military uniform, with his own signature inscribed at the lower-left corner. Beyond this national project, Perumal believed strongly that art should reach beyond galleries—he painted murals on the walls of Santhal homes around Santiniketan, decorating village life with motifs of trees, animals, and birds. Later, he settled in Madurai, and upon his death in 2004, he donated his personal collection to the Aravind Eye Hospital, ensuring its preservation and public access. His life and work reflect a rare balance: on one hand, he contributed to the elite, symbolic project of nation-building through the Constitution, while on the other, he remained deeply rooted in community-based practice, bringing art into ordinary spaces and affirming its place in both national history and everyday life.



Nibedita Bose

The artist worked on ornamental detailing.

Nibedita Bose remains a relatively obscure figure in the sources I consulted, yet her presence is noted among the collaborators credited in the calligraphy and art appendices of the Constitution of India manuscript. She is acknowledged primarily for her work on ornamental detailing and border embellishments, often in collaboration with other members of the Santiniketan team, contributing to pages that were designed by her colleagues. For instance, her name appears alongside border work in illustration pages that bridge mythological narratives and historical periods, indicating her role in

enhancing the visual and symbolic continuity of the manuscript. Although biographical information on her training, career trajectory, or later work is scarce, her inclusion among this cohort suggests she was likely a student or associate of Kala Bhavana, versed in the traditions of design, ornamentation, and possibly miniature or folk motifs. While her individual contributions may not have been foregrounded in mainstream accounts, her work nonetheless forms an integral part of the collaborative artistic effort, adding depth, intricacy, and a nuanced richness to the visual fabric of the Constitution manuscript.

Amala Sarkar

The artist contributed to border illustrations.

Amala Sarkar is one of the less extensively profiled artists associated with the making of the Constitution of India manuscript, yet her contributions, though often mentioned briefly in appendices and credits, are part of the collaborative artistry that defined the project. Her name appears in relation to calligraphic embellishments and decorative work, particularly in sections where visual design merges with textual presentation, suggesting a role that demanded both technical precision and aesthetic sensitivity. While biographical details about her early training, affiliations with Kala Bhavana, or later artistic career remain scarce, her presence in the Santiniketan team indicates that she, like many of her peers, was likely trained in the school's distinctive pedagogy that integrated fine art with craft traditions, especially in the areas of design and ornamentation. Her work, though not individually foregrounded in mainstream art historical narratives, embodies the collective spirit of the project, where multiple hands and styles came together to weave a visual framework that complemented the gravitas of the nation's founding document. In this sense, Amala Sarkar's contribution exemplifies the quiet but essential labour of artists whose detailing, borders, and ornament turned the Constitution into not just a legal text but a richly illustrated manuscript reflecting India's cultural plurality.

Dhirendra Krishna Deb Barman

Artist, worked on decorative panels.

Dhirendra Krishna Deb Barman (1903–1995) was a Santiniketan-trained artist from the Tripura royal family whose career bridges Tagore's early patronage, a sustained presence at Kala Bhavana, and visible contribution to the illustrated manuscript of the Constitution of India: he was singled out among the

team of illustrators and is credited with several key plates (including the Chhatrapati Shivaji and Guru Gobind Singh illustrations) while also being associated with mural and decorative commissions tied to the Tagore circle. Born into a family with close ties to Rabindranath Tagore, Deb Barman was supported to travel with Tagore's entourage to Java and Bali as a young artist—an early recognition that shaped his practice and placed him within international and colonial-era visual exchanges. Documentary and auction records show he exhibited and worked in tempera and wash techniques typical of the Santiniketan idiom (examples of his paintings appeared in Kala Bhavana/Nandan Gallery shows and later in auction catalogues), and institutional histories record him as a teacher and, at times, principal at Kala Bhavana—evidence that his career combined practice, pedagogy, and administrative responsibility within Visva-Bharati's art world. Despite these anchors, detailed personal archives (letters, a full catalogue raisonné, or a sustained monograph) are scattered and partly unpublished, so much of what we can reconstruct about his life—training before Santiniketan, precise dates for certain commissions, and the arc of his stylistic development—relies on institutional attributions, exhibition records, and government/press accounts rather than a single comprehensive biography. What this means for researchers is straightforward: Deb Barman's authorship on Constitution plates and his pedagogic role at Kala Bhavana are well attested and make him a significant, if under-documented, figure in twentieth-century Indian art; a fuller biography will require targeted archival work at Visva-Bharati, Tripura palace records, auction catalogues, and oral histories from Santiniketan alumni.

Gouri Bhanja

Assisted with illustrations and motifs.

Gouri Bhanja (1907-1998) was the eldest daughter of Nandalal Bose and emerged early as one of the first female students of Kala Bhavana; she graduated with a painting diploma around age 19, studying under her father and family mentors like Surendranath Kar. She worked for many years as a teacher at Kala Bhavana—handling alpana, batik, embroidery, mural design, and other applied arts—helping to formalise craft practices in Santiniketan. Importantly, she is credited among the artists who contributed to the original “illuminated” manuscript of the Indian Constitution, particularly in the ornamentation, border work, and illustrations under Nandalal Bose's leadership. Her artistic style combined influences from Ajanta murals and Indian miniature painting traditions, along with a sensitivity to rhythm, line, and decorative flourishing—whether in textiles, stage design, or floor art (alpana). Beyond the

manuscript, she also extended her design work to stage settings, festival decor, costume design for dance dramas (Chitrangada, Tasher Desh, etc.), and she is credited with introducing or systematising batik work and advancing applied arts pedagogy in Santiniketan. While her biography has gaps (precise details about which specific pages she individually illustrated in the Constitution beyond ornamentation, or a full catalogue of her non-Santiniketan exhibitions), her signature works and institutional records make clear she is a foundational figure among the Santiniketan circle whose contribution to the Constitution adds both stylistic richness and craft tradition to the manuscript.



Jamuna Sen

An artist from Santiniketan contributed to the decorative patterns.

Jamuna Sen (1912–2001), daughter of Nandalal Bose, grew up immersed in the creative and intellectual climate of Santiniketan and emerged as an important contributor to the artistic mission of India's Constitution. She studied at Kala Bhavana and later joined its faculty, working across multiple media, including design, batik, alpona, and murals. In the Art & Calligraphy in the Constitution project, Jamuna's name appears on the borders and frames of pages such as the Ramayana scene, the Mahavira meditation illustration, and parts of the Nalanda and Orissan sculpture pages, often signed "Jamuna" alongside Nandalal Bose or other collaborators. Her contributions balanced precision in motif design with sensitivity to narrative context, ensuring that ornamentation supported but did not overwhelm the illustration. Beyond the Constitution, Jamuna played a key role in design education and women's craft movements: she helped establish certificate courses in crafts at Santiniketan during the 1950s, led the revival of Karusangha (later Women Artists' Association), and promoted batik and other handicrafts as means for artistic and economic participation.



Jagdish Mittal

Assisted in illustration work (later became a noted art collector).

Jagdish Mittal (b. 1927), a distinguished yet less widely chronicled artist associated with the Constitution of India manuscript, is remembered for his meticulous approach to illustration and design. Born in

Lahore, Mittal later moved to Delhi, where he pursued formal training in fine arts, developing a style that combined precise line work with an appreciation for traditional Indian motifs. His involvement in the Constitution project positioned him among a generation of artists tasked with rendering the document both legible and visually resonant, balancing narrative clarity with decorative richness. Sources highlight his contributions to ornamental borders and figurative compositions, reflecting a careful synthesis of classical Indian aesthetics and contemporary sensibilities of the mid-20th century. While his role in the manuscript represents a key collaborative moment, Mittal's career extended into teaching, exhibitions, and independent commissions, allowing him to explore broader artistic concerns and regional influences. His work on the Constitution thus exemplifies both the collective enterprise of nation-building through art and the individual rigour and creativity he brought to Indian modernist practices.

Bani Patel

Worked on embellishments and supporting illustrations.

Bani Patel (1928–2018), the granddaughter of the celebrated artist Nandalal Bose and daughter of Gauri Bhanja, was a pivotal yet often overlooked contributor to the original manuscript of the Constitution of India. At just 21 years old, she was among the youngest artists to participate in this monumental project. Under the guidance of her grandfather, who led the artistic direction, Bani illustrated several pages of the Constitution using traditional brush painting techniques. One of her notable contributions includes the depiction of Lord Krishna delivering the Bhagavad Gita to Arjuna, featured in Part IV on the Directive Principles of State Policy. This artwork exemplifies her mastery of brush painting and her ability to encapsulate profound philosophical themes within intricate borders. Her signature, “Bani-Nanda,” appears alongside Nandalal Bose's on some of these pages, symbolising their collaborative effort. Bani Patel's involvement in the Constitution project not only highlights her artistic prowess but also underscores the rich legacy of artistic lineage that contributed to the visual identity of India's foundational legal document.

Rajniti

The artist contributed to borders and motifs.

Rajniti Singh, an artist associated with the Constitution of India manuscript, contributed to the visual narrative of the nation's foundational document. Her signature appears on the page depicting the life of Mahavir, illustrating Part VI of the Constitution, which deals with 'The States in Part A of the First Schedule'. This richly coloured illustration portrays Mahavir in meditation, flanked by blooming trees and a peacock, symbolising harmony and spiritual enlightenment. The frame of this artwork bears Rajniti's signature, reflecting her contribution to this significant project.



Kripal Singh Shekhwat

Specialist in Jaipur-style miniature painting, added Rajasthani elements.

Kripal Singh Shekhawat (1922–2008), a distinguished artist and ceramist from Rajasthan, is celebrated for his contributions both to Indian miniature painting and the revival of Jaipur's iconic blue pottery. Born in Mau, Rajasthan, he was immersed from an early age in the region's rich artistic traditions and later trained at Santiniketan under Nandalal Bose, which profoundly shaped his artistic vision. In 1946, Shekhawat was selected as one of the contributing artists to the original manuscript of the Constitution of India, where his work appears on the border design of the page depicting the life of Mahavir in Part VI, symbolising harmony and spiritual enlightenment through richly colored imagery. His training in Santiniketan, combined with a diploma in Oriental Arts from Tokyo University, allowed him to synthesise Indian and Japanese artistic sensibilities, lending his work both precision and a nuanced aesthetic depth. Beyond the Constitution project, Shekhawat played a pivotal role in reviving Jaipur blue pottery, modernising its techniques and palette to ensure its continuity, and earning recognition through the Padma Shri in 1974 and the title of Shilp Guru in 2002. His legacy is a blend of artistic innovation, cultural preservation, and national contribution, reflecting a lifelong commitment to enriching India's visual and material heritage.



Prem Behari Narayan Raizada

Calligrapher, handwrote the entire Constitution in italic script (without charging any fee).

Prem Behari Narain Raizada (1901–1966) was the master calligrapher responsible for hand-inscribing the original manuscript of the Constitution of India—an extraordinary task that combined aesthetic elegance with national symbolism. Born into a family of calligraphers in Delhi, Raizada inherited his craft from his grandfather, a noted Persian and English calligrapher in the Mughal court. A graduate of St. Stephen’s College, Delhi, he possessed both a scholarly command of language and a refined sense of design. When asked by Jawaharlal Nehru to write the Constitution by hand, Raizada agreed on the condition that he would not accept payment, but that his name and that of his grandfather would appear on every page—a request that was graciously fulfilled. Over six months, working with devotion and precision, he wrote the entire document in an elegant italic style using a holder and nib, on parchment sheets sourced from handmade paper in Pune. The Constitution, consisting of 395 articles and 8 schedules at the time, spans nearly a thousand pages, each richly adorned with illustrations by Nandalal Bose and his team from Santiniketan. Raizada’s calligraphy gave the text its visual rhythm, ensuring legibility while complementing the surrounding artwork. His work transformed the Constitution from a legal manuscript into a work of art—a symbol of both intellectual and cultural craftsmanship at the dawn of India’s democracy.

Vasant K. Vaidya

Artist, worked on embellishments and design support

Vasant Krishanrao Vaidya (1919–1998) was the chief calligrapher of the Hindi version of the Constitution of India, a monumental work that demanded precision, aesthetic sensitivity, and deep commitment to linguistic and cultural expression. Born in Maharashtra, Vaidya trained in fine arts at the Sir J. J. School of Art in Bombay, where he developed an early fascination with typography and manuscript design. His expertise in calligraphy, particularly in Devanagari, earned him recognition within artistic circles, eventually leading to his selection by Nandalal Bose to handwrite the Hindi manuscript of the Constitution. Working in close collaboration with Bose and the team at Kala Bhavana, Santiniketan, Vaidya brought to life a manuscript that mirrored the English version written by Prem Behari Narain Raizada, while adapting it gracefully to the rhythm and structure of the Devanagari script. Every page he inscribed was embellished with borders and motifs by Santiniketan artists, blending linguistic beauty with visual symbolism. The Hindi Constitution, like its English counterpart, was written on parchment handmade in Pune and took nearly six months to complete. Beyond this historic

project, Vaidya continued his career as an educator and designer, contributing to the promotion of Indian calligraphy and manuscript traditions through teaching and exhibitions. His contribution ensured that the Hindi text of India’s supreme legal document stood not only as a translation but as an independent work of artistic and cultural significance—embodying the spirit of a newly independent, multilingual nation.



Sumitra Narayan
 Artist, contributed to border motifs and calligraphic flourishes.

Sumitra Narayan (née Benegal, b. 1929) was one of the artists from Kala Bhavana, Santiniketan, who contributed to illustrating the original manuscript of the Constitution of India. Born in Secunderabad (Hyderabad State), she came to Kala Bhavana around 1949 and studied there until about 1953 under Gouri Bhanja, acquiring skills in traditional art forms, including alpona. Although Bengali was not her mother tongue (she spoke Konkani), she gradually learned it during her time at Santiniketan. Her signature appears on one of the borders in the Constitution manuscript, marking her contribution to the decorative framing of the document. After her formal art education, she joined Patha Bhavan School in Kolkata, teaching Arts & Crafts from 1965 until about 1991, and Alpona remained one of her preferred forms of artistic expression.

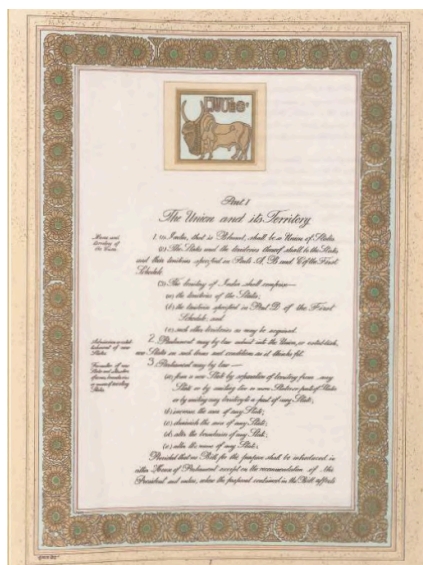
Illustration Analysis

Illustration	Analysis
	This first page of the Constitution is not just ornamental; it establishes the symbolic foundation of the entire manuscript. The illustration depicts the Lion Capital of Ashoka, chosen as the National Emblem of India, accompanied by the words <i>Satyameva Jayate</i> in Devanagari, which became the nation’s guiding motto. The emblem itself is deeply layered: four lions (three visible, the fourth implied) stand atop a circular abacus decorated with four animals: lion, bull, elephant, and horse, each separated by an Ashoka Chakra. Together, these elements evoke India’s ancient Buddhist heritage, Ashoka’s vision of moral governance, and the continuity of dharma through time. What is striking in this painted version is the attention to

authenticity and vitality. Under the guidance of Nandalal Bose, Dinanath Bhargava carefully studied living lions at the Kolkata Zoo to capture accurate musculature, expressions, and presence. This naturalistic observation distinguishes the emblem from being a flat reproduction of the Sarnath sculpture, instead lending it life, movement, and a sense of guardianship. The lions appear protective yet dignified, their stance embodying strength rooted in moral authority rather than brute force.

The border framing the emblem complements its centrality: intricate floral and geometric motifs in gold, red, and green reflect the manuscript's hand-crafted richness, while also grounding the emblem in India's broader artistic traditions. The inclusion of *Satyameva Jayate* ties the visual to a philosophical truth that transcends politics, asserting that legitimacy rests on truth and justice.

Placed at the opening of the manuscript, this page works as a visual preamble to the text that follows. It sets the tone for the entire Constitution, affirming that the document is not only a legal framework but also a moral and cultural compact. The emblem and its framing imagery signal continuity with India's past while projecting the ethical aspirations of a newly independent nation.

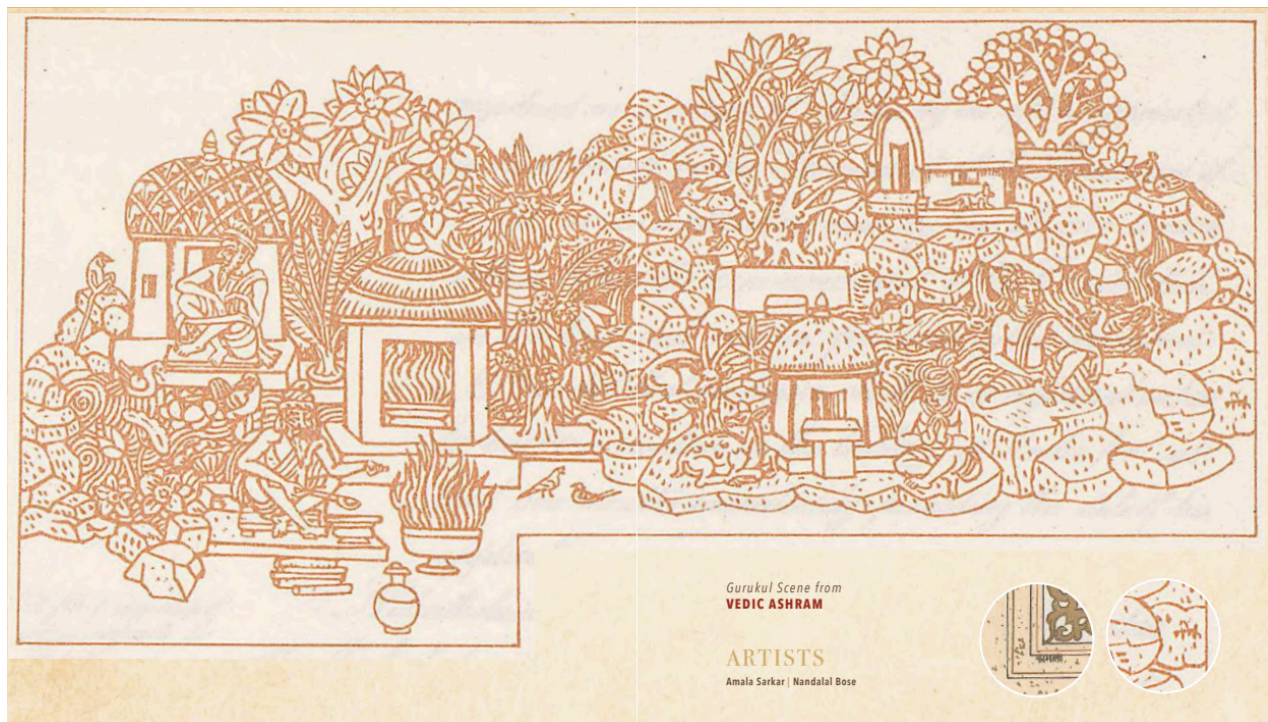


This illustrated page introduces **Part I of the Constitution, *The Union and its Territory***, framed with an image that connects the founding text of modern India to its ancient roots. At the top is the figure of a robust bull drawn from the well-known seal of the Indus Valley Civilisation at Mohenjo-Daro. The bull seal is one of the most recognisable symbols of Harappan art, often understood as a marker of fertility, energy, and prosperity, as well as a reference to the networks of trade and exchange that supported early urban life. By placing this motif at the beginning of the constitutional text, the artists establish a deliberate link between India's deep civilizational past and the aspirations of the newly independent republic, suggesting continuity, strength, and leadership.

The artwork is attributed to **Beohar Rammanohar Sinha**, while the ornate border around the text carries the signature of **Kripal Singh Shekhawat**. Their collaboration reflects the collective ethos of the Constitution manuscript project under the direction of Nandalal Bose, where the talents of multiple artists came together to give the document its distinctive visual character. The border itself, richly detailed with stylised floral and geometric patterns, provides a decorative frame that enhances both the solemnity and

the beauty of the text.

Through this careful placement of the Harappan bull, the Constitution is visually anchored in a narrative that stretches from the achievements of the subcontinent's earliest civilisations to the forging of a modern democratic state. It reminds the reader that the principles outlined in the text are not only forward-looking but also rooted in a long continuum of cultural endurance and innovation.

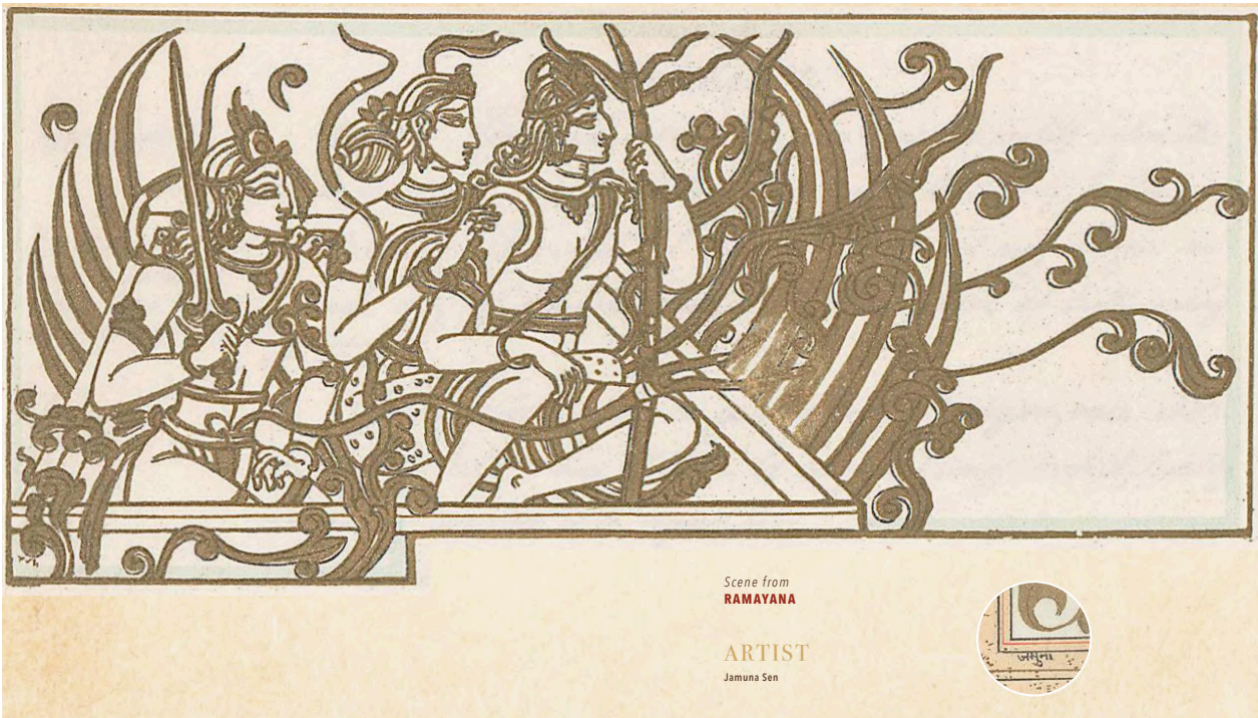


This illustration introduces **Part II of the Constitution**, which addresses the theme of citizenship, through a visual evocation of a Vedic ashram. The scene depicts a gurukul environment where ascetics are shown engaged in prayer, teaching, and ritual offerings, with yajnas burning at the centre. The architecture of simple thatched huts, the abundance of flowering trees, and the surrounding rocky landscape situate the scene in a timeless natural setting, where learning and spiritual practice unfold in harmony with the environment. By foregrounding the gurukul, a space historically associated with education, discipline, and the transmission of knowledge, the illustration symbolically connects the idea of citizenship with the virtues of awareness, wisdom, and responsibility that guide civic life.

The artwork is jointly credited to **Amala Sarkar and Nandalal Bose**, whose signatures appear on the page. Their choice of a Vedic ashram underscores the constitutional vision of India as a community bound together not only by law but also by a deeper cultural ethos that values collective learning and ethical grounding. The visual vocabulary, restrained in palette yet rich in detail, highlights the significance of knowledge as the foundation for building a responsible and participatory citizenry.

Placed at the opening of the section on citizenship, this gurukul scene does more than decorate the text. It establishes a philosophical frame, suggesting that the rights and duties of citizenship are inseparable from a culture of learning, reflection, and moral growth. By invoking the imagery of the ashram, the

Constitution aligns the ideals of modern nationhood with India's long traditions of cultivating knowledge and wisdom as the basis of social life.



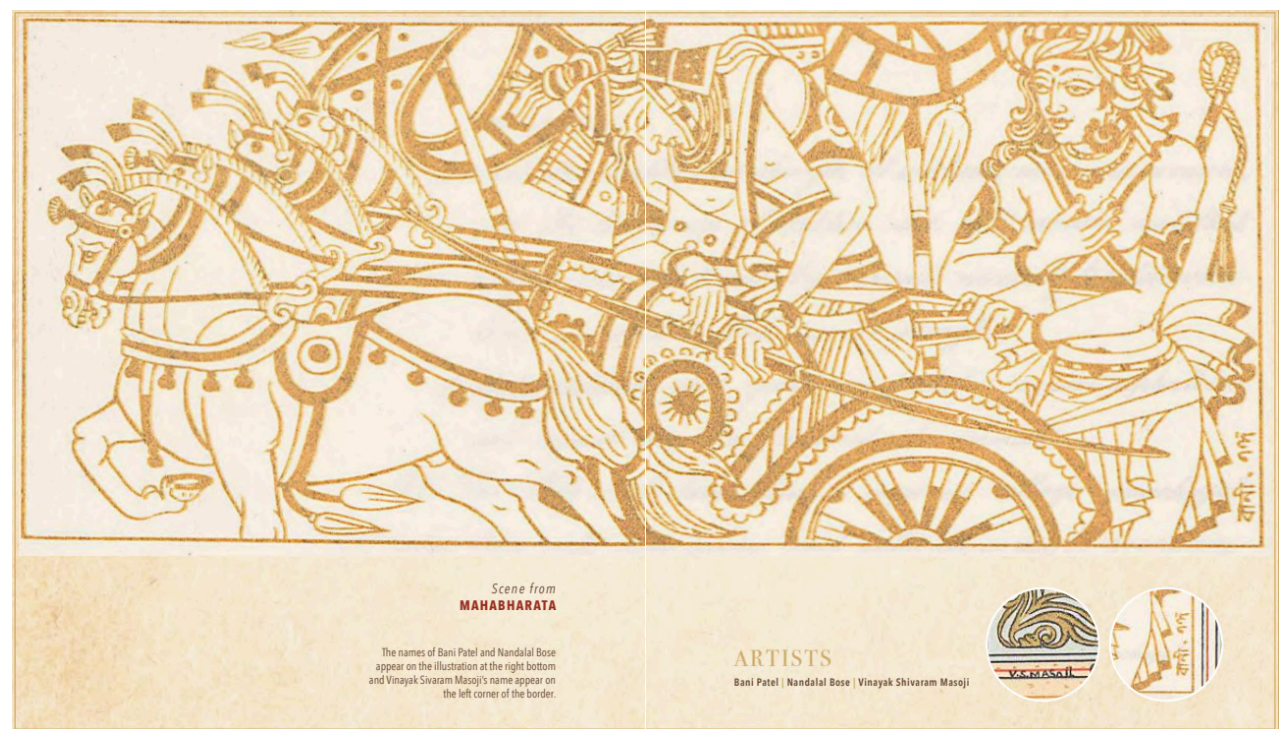
This illustration marks the opening of **Part III of the Constitution, which outlines the Fundamental Rights**—those essential guarantees of freedom, equality, and justice that form the moral and legal backbone of the Republic. To introduce this section, the image turns to one of the most enduring moral narratives in Indian thought: a scene from the Ramayana. Depicted here are Shri Ram, Sita Mata, and Shri Lakshman, seated together amidst a rhythmic flow of foliage and ornamentation. The composition captures not a moment of battle or grandeur, but of poised movement—an image of harmony, restraint, and quiet strength that mirrors the constitutional values of discipline and righteousness.

The trio, bound by duty and guided by dharma, embody the ethical core of the Ramayana: the victory of good over evil, truth over falsehood, and justice over tyranny. In the context of the Constitution, their presence becomes more than devotional—it is philosophical. Just as Ram's triumph over Ravan represents the moral order prevailing over chaos, the Fundamental Rights affirm the rule of law as the guardian of justice and the protector of human dignity. The illustration thus translates a mythic ideal into a civic one, suggesting that freedom without righteousness, or power without restraint, cannot endure.

Rendered in a limited, earthy palette, the artwork's visual rhythm—interlacing vines, flowing garments, and balanced gestures—reflects the influence of the Bengal School, especially the Santiniketan tradition that sought to merge classical Indian sensibilities with modern expression. The artist, **Jamuna Sen**, inscribes her name in Bengali on the border, subtly situating the work within that lineage of cultural revival and reform that shaped early twentieth-century Indian art. Her style, delicate yet assured, invites the viewer to look beyond the narrative surface and sense the moral atmosphere that underpins it.

By placing this Ramayana scene at the beginning of the section on Fundamental Rights, the

Constitution's visual programme makes a profound statement. It frames the idea of rights not merely as entitlements but as expressions of ethical responsibility—a reminder that personal freedom must coexist with social duty. In doing so, the illustration bridges the epic's timeless moral order with the modern Republic's legal and moral framework, uniting the ancient pursuit of dharma with the contemporary promise of justice, liberty, and equality for all.



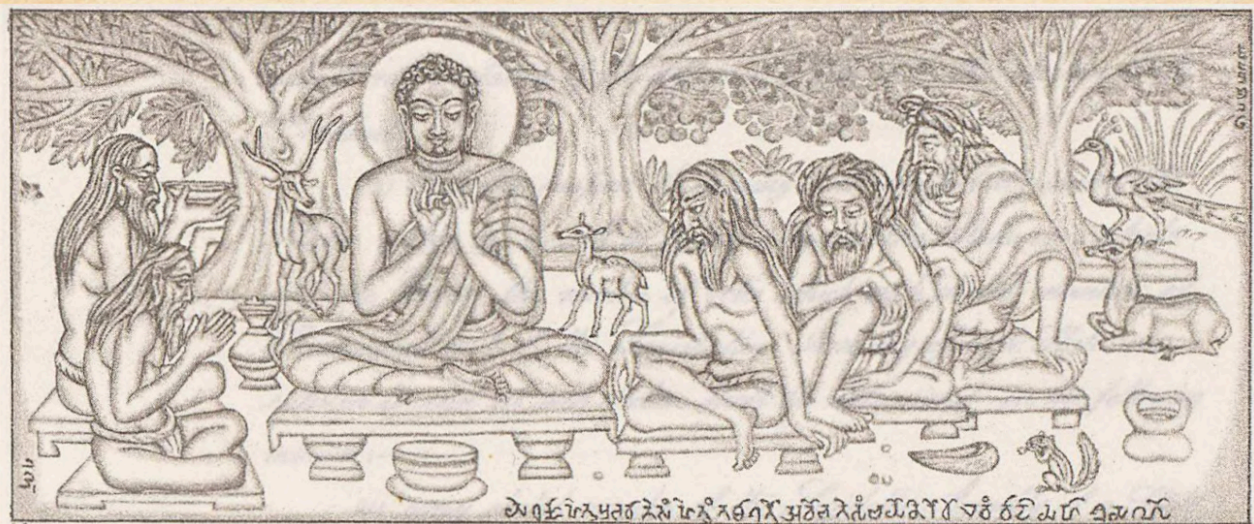
This illustration introduces **Part IV of the Constitution, which sets out the Directive Principles of State Policy**—those moral and social ideals meant to guide the State in shaping a just and equitable society. Drawing upon one of the most profound moments in Indian philosophical tradition, the scene portrays Krishna counselling Arjuna on the battlefield of Kurukshetra. The chariot surges forward, its horses alive with motion, while Arjuna, momentarily stilled in doubt, listens intently to Krishna's words. This exchange, captured with remarkable economy of line and form, represents the timeless dialogue between action and conscience, between the individual's moral duty and the larger ethical order.

In the *Mahabharata*, this is the instant before the great war begins—the pause between turmoil and resolve. Arjuna's hesitation mirrors the human struggle to reconcile personal duty with universal justice, while Krishna's guidance transforms that hesitation into purposeful action. Within the constitutional context, this image finds deep resonance: just as Krishna's counsel anchors Arjuna's moral clarity, the Directive Principles serve as the Republic's moral compass. They do not command by force of law but inspire through vision—urging the State towards equality, welfare, and collective responsibility.

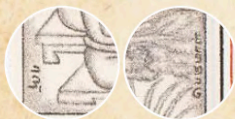
Executed in a warm, ochre tone, the composition combines dynamism with composure. The flowing lines of the horses and the circular rhythm of the chariot wheels create a sense of movement balanced by the calm authority of Krishna's gesture. The artistic collaboration between **Bani Patel, Nandalal Bose, and Vinayak Shivaram Masoji** reflects the shared aesthetic of the Shantiniketan school, where traditional Indian forms were revitalised to express the ideals of a modern nation. Their signatures, discreetly placed along the borders, attest to this collective creative enterprise that defined the visual

identity of the Constitution.

Positioned at the beginning of the section on the Directive Principles, the Mahabharata scene operates as more than ornamentation—it is a moral invocation. It reminds readers that governance, like action in the Gita, must arise from discernment and duty, not desire or self-interest. Through the visual idiom of the epic, the Constitution asserts that the ethical vision of the State must be guided, like Arjuna, by wisdom, compassion, and an unwavering commitment to the greater good.



Scene from the life of
BUDDHA



The illustration on this page was executed by Nivedita Bose, A Perumal and Nandalal Bose. Nivedita's signature appears on the lower part of the left border. Nandalal Bose's sign is visible on the lower left corner of the illustration and A. Perumal leaves his sign on the right top of the illustration.

ARTISTS

Nivedita Bose | A. Perumal | Nandalal Bose



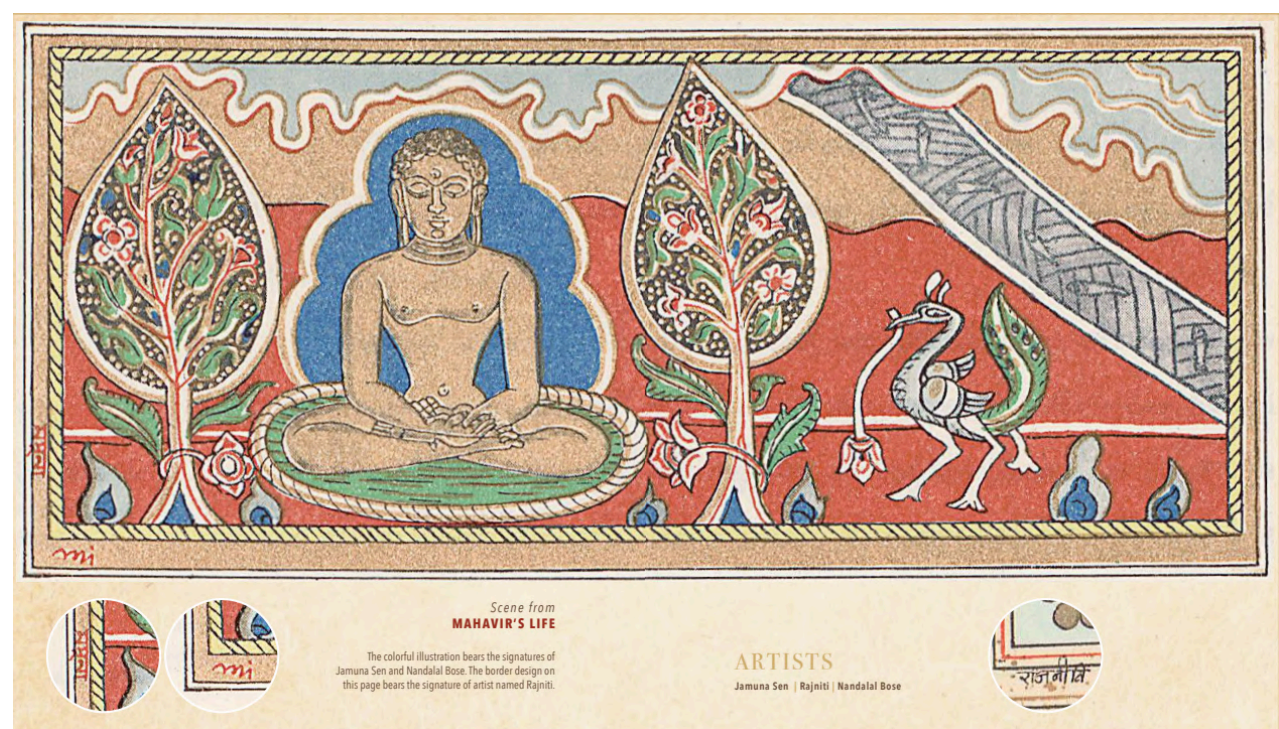
This illustration introduces **Part V of the Constitution, which outlines the framework of the Union Government**, through a scene from the life of the Buddha. Depicted here is the moment of the *Dharmachakra Pravartana Sutra*—the first sermon delivered by the Buddha at Isipatana, the deer park of Sarnath, shortly after his enlightenment. Under the shade of a broad, serene tree, the Buddha sits in meditation posture, hands raised in the gesture of teaching. Around him are his first five disciples, their faces intent with reverence and reflection, as deer and birds quietly share the space—a reminder of the compassion that extends to all living beings.

This moment, known as the Setting in Motion of the Wheel of Dharma, marks the beginning of the Buddha's teaching journey. It was here that he articulated the Four Noble Truths, the essence of his philosophy: the nature of suffering, its cause, its cessation, and the path leading to liberation. In the context of the Constitution, this scene carries layered meaning. Just as the Buddha's sermon offered a moral and intellectual compass to his followers, Part V of the Constitution lays out the guiding principles for governance—seeking balance between authority and compassion, order and wisdom. The serenity of the scene contrasts with the weight of its message: governance, like the path of Dharma, demands clarity of vision and moral restraint.

The artwork, executed collaboratively by **Nivedita Bose, A. Perumal, and Nandalal Bose**, bears the signatures of all three along its borders. Their rendering combines stillness and detail with a fine linear

rhythm characteristic of the Shantiniketan school. The deer park, drawn with quiet natural grace, situates the spiritual act within a living landscape, blurring the line between the human and the natural world. The soft, monochrome shading evokes calm contemplation rather than grandeur, inviting the viewer into the meditative ethos of the moment.

Placed at the opening of Part V, the scene performs more than an illustrative role. It establishes a tone of mindful governance—suggesting that the true exercise of power rests on understanding, patience, and ethical reflection. By invoking the Buddha’s first sermon, the Constitution connects the structure of modern statecraft to India’s ancient philosophical tradition, where leadership begins not with dominance, but with the pursuit of wisdom and the turning of the wheel of justice.



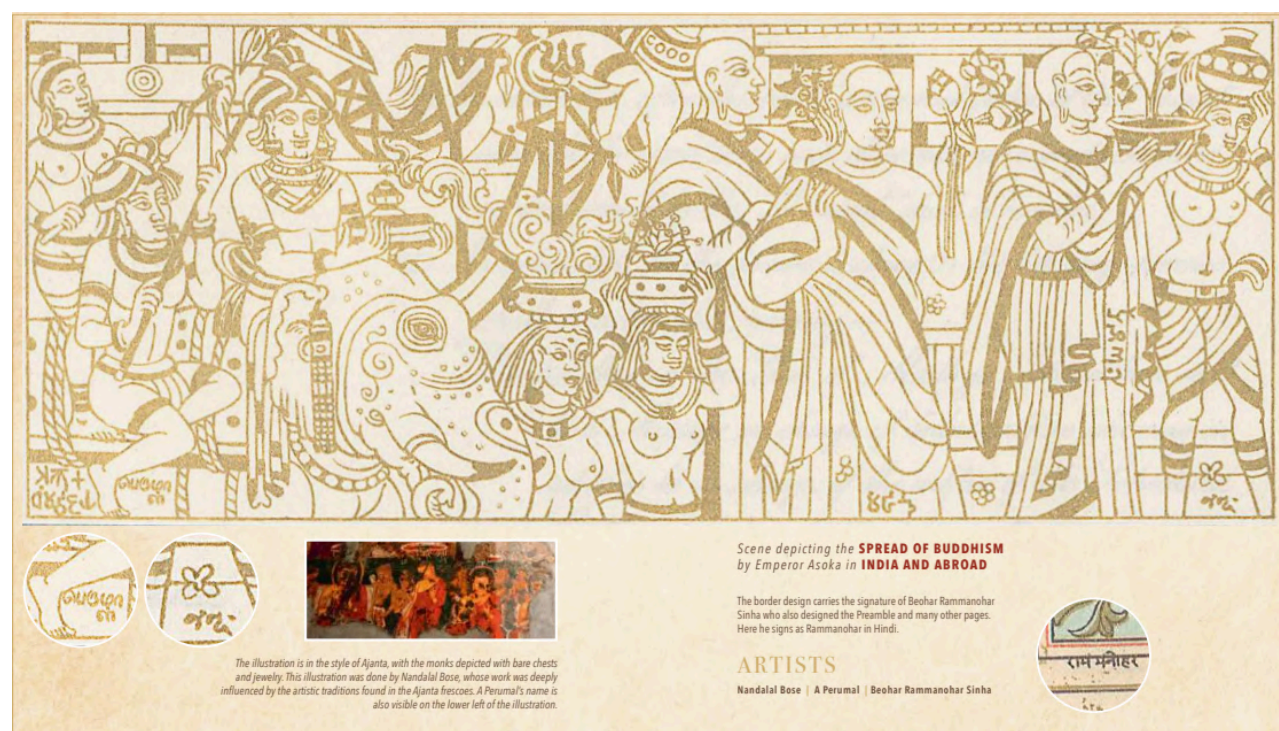
This illustration introduces **Part VI of the Constitution**, which lays out the framework for the **States listed in Part A of the First Schedule**, through a contemplative scene from the life of Mahavira, the twenty-fourth and final Tirthankara of the Jain tradition in this era. Mahavira is depicted here in deep meditation, seated in a cross-legged posture, palms resting one over the other in quiet concentration. His eyes are closed, signalling renunciation of the material world and an inward turning toward liberation. On either side of him rise flowering trees, their branches heavy with blossoms, while to his right a peacock stands alert, its plumage rendered in fine ornamental detail. The setting evokes harmony between the spiritual and the natural, aligning Mahavira’s message of *ahimsa*—non-violence—with the wider environment that sustains all beings.

The choice of *Mahavira* at the threshold of Part VI carries layered meaning. In Jain philosophy, the discipline of meditation is not merely withdrawal but a conscious act of self-governance over desires, actions, and intentions. Likewise, Part VI of the Constitution concerns the governance of the States, demanding clarity, restraint, and moral grounding in their relations with the Union and with one another. The meditating figure of Mahavira becomes an allegory of governance itself: power exercised without inner control risks disorder, but power guided by self-mastery and compassion creates balance

and order. The surrounding trees, fertile and symmetrical, symbolise growth under such balance, while the presence of the peacock suggests the beauty that emerges when restraint and vitality coexist.

This illustration is distinctive for its vivid palette—reds, greens, and blues woven together in bold contrast. Unlike the many monochrome pages of the Constitution, this scene is alive with colour, giving it a celebratory yet contemplative aura. It was executed collaboratively, bearing the signatures of Jamuna Sen and Nandalal Bose, two prominent artists of the Shantiniketan circle, whose style often combined simplicity of line with cultural symbolism. The border design, more geometric in form, carries the signature of the artist Rajniti, blending decoration with narrative content.

Placed at the opening of Part VI, this image performs more than an illustrative role. It establishes a tone for the interpretation of state governance: just as Mahavira's life taught that liberation arises through self-discipline, compassion, and harmony, so too does the Constitution suggest that the stability of states within the Union depends on ethical restraint, balance of authority, and peaceful coexistence. In this way, the meditation of a Tirthankara becomes a metaphor for the discipline of statecraft—quiet strength, moral clarity, and harmony as the foundations of enduring order.



This illustration introduces **Part VII of the Constitution**, which addresses the **States in Part B of the First Schedule**, through a dramatic scene depicting the spread of Buddhism under the patronage of Emperor Ashoka. The central figure, Ashoka himself, is shown atop a richly adorned elephant, the animal's grand finery underscoring both royal authority and the ceremonial nature of the procession. Around him gather monks and attendants, some carrying offerings, others bearing symbols of devotion—pots filled with flowering plants, gestures of reverence, and instruments of ritual. The scene is alive with movement, echoing the dynamism of a tradition spreading across frontiers.

Executed in the style of the Ajanta murals, the illustration captures the distinct grace of that artistic lineage. Figures are depicted with bare chests and adorned with jewellery, their postures fluid, their

expressions serene yet purposeful. This visual language connects the Constitution to India's ancient artistic heritage, reminding the reader that cultural continuity is as essential to nationhood as political organisation. The style also evokes the blending of power and piety that characterised Ashoka's transformation after the Kalinga war—his shift from conquest by arms to conquest by Dharma.

Placed at the beginning of Part VII, the scene functions as a metaphor for integration and dissemination. Just as Ashoka extended Buddhism beyond India's borders, knitting together lands with shared ideals of compassion and peace, the Constitution here contemplates the integration of Part B states into the Union—distinct entities, yet bound within a common framework. The procession becomes symbolic of a journey: the flow of values and governance that transforms multiplicity into unity. In this way, the image links imperial legacy with democratic structure, suggesting that the binding force of a polity lies not in coercion but in the shared acceptance of principles.

The illustration bears the hallmark of collaboration. **Nandalal Bose**, deeply inspired by Ajanta's traditions, lent the fluid line and rhythmic movement that define the composition. The signature of **A. Perumal** is also visible, affirming the collective spirit of its creation. The border design is signed by **Beohar Rammanohar Sinha**, who also designed the Constitution's Preamble and numerous other pages, here writing his name as Rammanohar in Hindi. Together, their work ties the scene to both a historic and modern lineage: from the caves of Ajanta to the document of the Constitution, artistic expression becomes a bridge across centuries.

More than illustration, this page sets a tone. Ashoka's procession is not merely a historical memory but a parable: governance that endures must move beyond conquest, toward compassion and shared purpose. Just as the elephant carries the emperor not as a symbol of domination but as a bearer of Dharma, so too does the Constitution suggest that statehood, even in its diversity, must be carried forward on the principles of justice, peace, and unity.



Scene from
GUPTA ART

The illustration is one of the images attributed to Beohar Rammanohar Sinha, but does not bear his signature since he believed this was work done for the nation and undertook the whole project in that spirit. Kripal Singh Shekhawat's signature in Devanagari is visible on the border of this page

ARTIST
Kripal Singh Shekhawat



This illustration introduces **Part VIII of the Constitution**, which addresses the **States listed in Part**

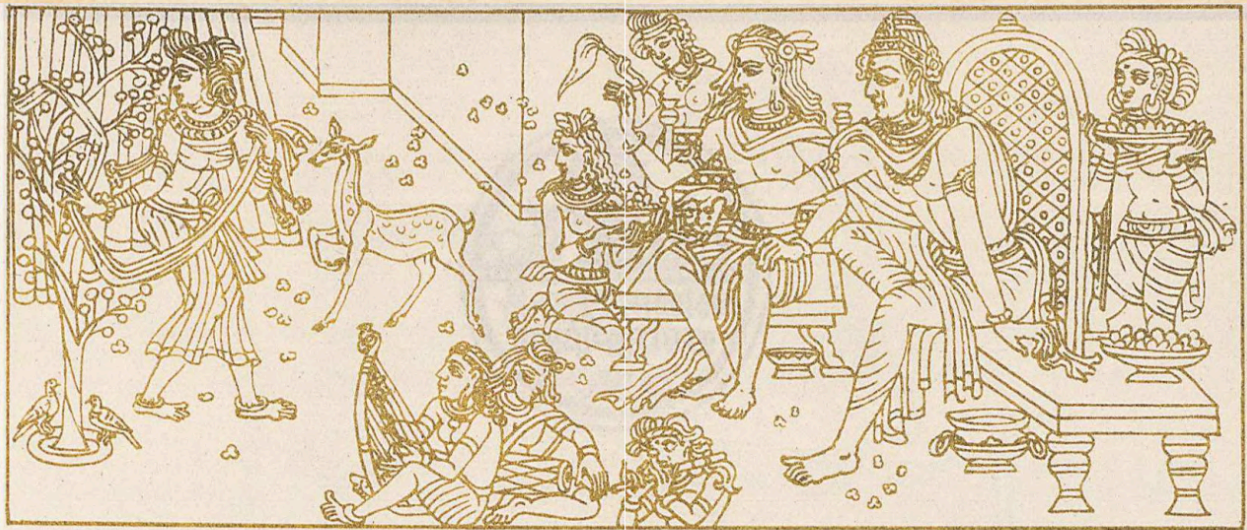
C of the First Schedule, through a striking evocation of *Gupta art*. At the centre of the composition is a richly adorned Gandharva—a celestial being from Hindu mythology, associated with music, harmony, and the role of intermediary between the human and the divine. The Gandharva, dressed in elaborate ornaments and a turban, gestures outward with an expressive arm, suggesting movement, communication, and flow. His figure is dynamic, leaning across the panel as if bridging two realms, while his jewellery and textiles evoke the opulent refinement characteristic of Gupta aesthetics. To the left of the frame, a lush tree in bloom, heavy with fruit and foliage, emphasises the abundance and fertility often celebrated in this golden age of Indian art. Behind him, stylised architectural motifs and geometric forms remind the viewer of the Gupta era's balance between spiritual symbolism and structural elegance.

The choice of a Gandharva at the threshold of Part VIII resonates deeply with the constitutional context. Gandharvas in Indian tradition were not only celestial musicians but also messengers who carried divine communication across realms. In this role, they embodied the bridging of boundaries, the weaving together of distinct worlds into a larger harmony. Similarly, Part VIII deals with the governance of Part C states—territories often diverse in character and history, yet brought into the constitutional framework of the Union. Just as the Gandharva mediates between divine and human, this Part suggests mediation between local distinctiveness and national unity. The figure, adorned and airborne, becomes a metaphor for integration: a being suspended between spaces, yet belonging to both.

Artistically, the illustration is informed by the ideals of Gupta art, a period often regarded as the classical pinnacle of Indian aesthetics. The Gupta style emphasised clarity of form, grace of movement, and symbolic richness, all of which are visible here—the poised limbs, the careful ornamentation, the gentle flow of lines. The floral cluster to the left recalls both natural beauty and fertility, hallmarks of Gupta decorative motifs, while the figure's rhythmic posture reflects the age's love for movement harmonised with spiritual purpose.

This page also carries the layered legacy of its makers. While the composition is often attributed to **Beohar Rammanohar Sinha**, he deliberately refrained from signing it, considering the Constitution not as a project of individual recognition but as an offering to the nation. Instead, the signature visible on the border is that of Kripal Singh Shekhawat, inscribed in Devanagari. This act of collective authorship mirrors the collaborative spirit of the Constitution itself, where many hands and voices came together to shape a single guiding document.

Placed at the opening of Part VIII, the scene sets a tone of fluid connection. Just as the Gandharva is a symbol of music, communication, and transcendence, the Constitution here frames governance as a harmonising force—integrating territories of varied histories into one federal structure. The image reminds us that governance, like music, depends not on domination but on rhythm, balance, and the careful blending of distinct notes into a shared melody. In invoking Gupta art and its celestial messengers, the Constitution situates its modern statecraft within India's cultural continuum, where art, myth, and governance are all expressions of a deeper pursuit of harmony.



Scene from the Court of
KING VIKRAMADITYA

ARTIST
Jamuna Sen



This illustration introduces **Part IX of the Constitution, which concerns the Territories in Part D of the First Schedule**, through a graceful depiction of the legendary court of *King Vikramaditya*. The composition unfolds as a refined tableau of royal leisure and cultural splendour. At its centre, King Vikramaditya sits upon an intricately patterned throne, surrounded by courtiers and attendants, his posture composed yet animated, embodying both authority and intellectual curiosity. Around him, musicians and dancers enliven the scene, while a graceful deer and a flowering tree to the left infuse the setting with natural vitality. The gentle sweep of lines, the poised gestures, and the rhythmic arrangement of figures recall the elegance of early classical Indian art, where refinement and restraint coexist with expressive vitality.

Vikramaditya, whose name fuses *vikrama* (valour) and *aditya* (sun), has long stood as a cultural archetype of enlightened kingship—one who nurtured the arts, literature, and philosophy. His legendary court, said to host the celebrated ‘Nine Gems,’ symbolised a golden synthesis of intellect, creativity, and governance. In this constitutional context, the evocation of his court suggests a realm where knowledge and art thrive under just leadership, mirroring the ideals of civic harmony and collective progress envisioned in the Constitution. The artist, **Jamuna Sen**, captures this ethos with delicate precision—the ornamental motifs, stylised drapery, and expressive hands forming a language of refinement deeply rooted in Indian aesthetics.

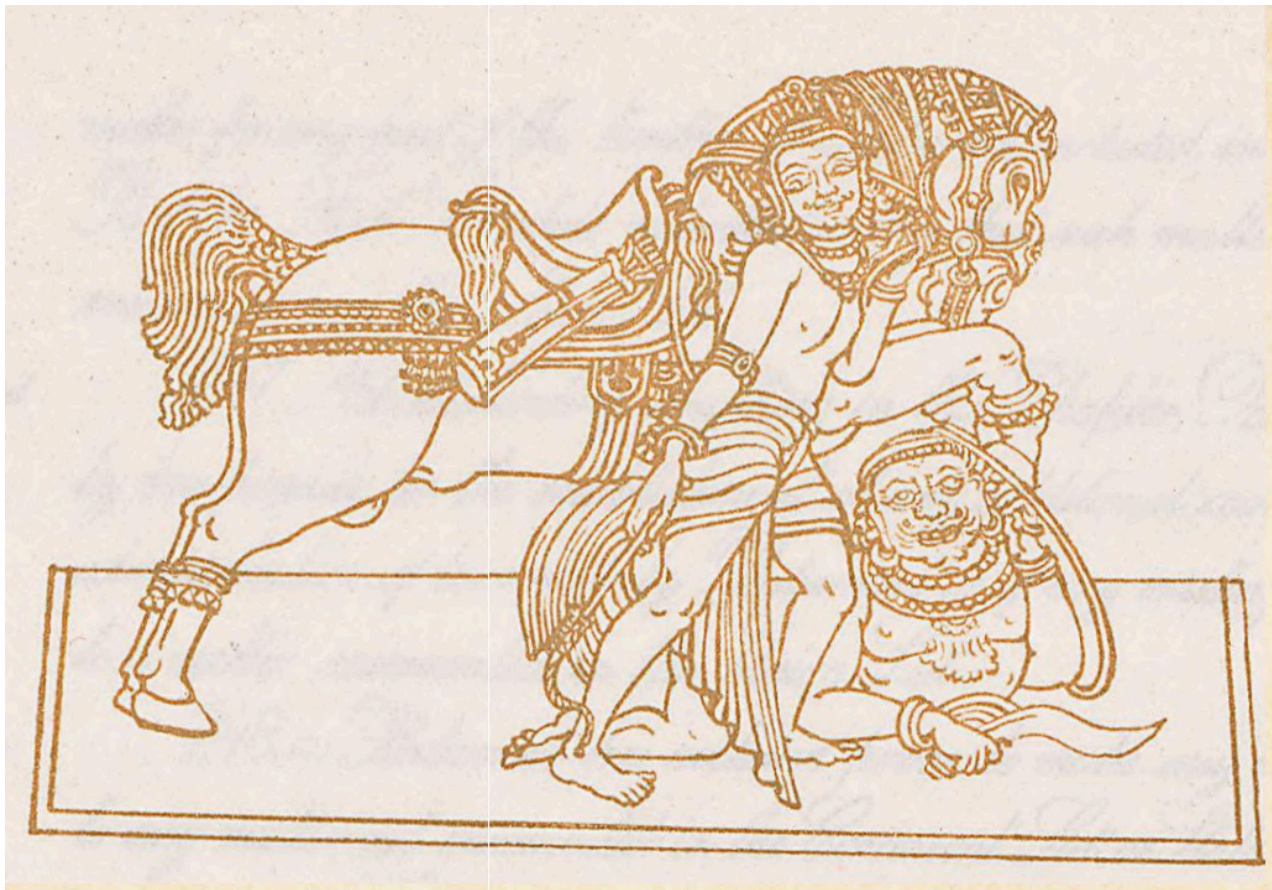
Artistically, the illustration stands as a dialogue between memory and modernity. Sen’s treatment of line—fine yet decisive—echoes the narrative clarity of early mural traditions, while her choice of composition evokes an atmosphere of contemplative grace rather than ostentation. The serenity of the court scene becomes more than historical—it becomes aspirational, a metaphor for governance founded on intellect and empathy. Just as Vikramaditya’s court is remembered as a confluence of wisdom and beauty, Part IX also gestures towards a polity that integrates diversity with dignity. Through this image, the Constitution honours India’s artistic and philosophical heritage, suggesting that culture itself is a form of governance—a way of ordering the world through grace, imagination, and balance.



This illustration marks the beginning of **Part X of the Constitution, which addresses the Scheduled and Tribal Areas**, through an evocative portrayal of Nalanda—one of ancient India’s most renowned centres of learning. The scene unfolds in a rhythm of calm precision: monks in flowing robes sit engaged in study and discourse, their gestures gentle yet intent, their expressions serene. Behind them rises a stylised panorama of domed shrines, stupas, and monastery structures, rendered in architectural harmony that recalls the grandeur of the original Mahavihara. Birds glide above and trees bloom at the margins, weaving nature into this ordered world of scholarship. The linework is disciplined and luminous, with golden accents tracing both the intellectual and spiritual radiance that Nalanda once embodied.

Founded in the early centuries of the Common Era and flourishing for over 800 years, Nalanda was more than a university—it was a living monastery, an ecosystem of inquiry that drew students and teachers from across Asia. Its inclusion here symbolises not only India’s ancient commitment to education and dialogue but also the Constitution’s recognition of knowledge as a means of empowerment and inclusion. In invoking Nalanda at the threshold of Part X, the artists suggest that the ideals of shared learning and respect for difference remain central to India’s social fabric—principles that resonate strongly with the spirit of constitutional protection for diverse communities.

The stylistic language of the illustration reflects Shekhawat’s mastery of the Jaipur miniature tradition and Bose’s sensitivity to narrative structure. Their lines are sparse yet expressive, balancing ornament and order much like Nalanda balanced intellect and devotion. The seal above the panel, featuring the *Dharma Chakra* flanked by two cows, anchors the image within India’s emblematic vocabulary of moral law and sustenance. In the lower corners, the artists’ signatures remind us that this work, like the Constitution itself, is the result of collaboration—a shared act of creation. Framed at the opening of Part X, the Nalanda scene transforms an ancient image of learning into a timeless metaphor for equality and understanding, urging the reader to view governance as a continuing education in compassion, coexistence, and wisdom.



This illustration introduces **Part XI of the Constitution**, which addresses the relations between the **Union and the States**, through a composition inspired by the famed war horse sculpture of the Sun Temple at Konark, Odisha. The scene is rendered with rhythmic precision and dynamic balance: a powerful horse, richly adorned with harness and trappings, rears over a subdued figure beneath its hooves, while a warrior stands beside it, poised in control. His body, gracefully curved and taut with strength, conveys both motion and mastery. The intricate linework captures the elaborate ornamentation of the Konark style—the finely patterned mane, the jewelled harness, and the flowing drapery—imbuing the scene with both energy and elegance.

The choice of the Konark warhorse as the visual emblem for this Part of the Constitution carries profound symbolism. The horse, representing vitality and disciplined power, mirrors the dynamic yet balanced relationship between the Union and the States—forces of strength that must act in coordination rather than conflict. The warrior's composure amidst action suggests governance guided by restraint and harmony, qualities essential to a federal structure. Artist **Jamuna Sen**, with border embellishments by Amala Sarkar, translates the grandeur of Orissan sculpture into a linear idiom that remains faithful to its spirit while fitting seamlessly within the visual language of the Constitution's art.

Stylistically, the illustration reflects the architectural and sculptural sophistication of medieval Odisha, known for its interplay of movement, geometry, and symbolic depth. The forms are assertive yet poised, sculptural yet fluid, echoing the vitality of the Konark carvings that once celebrated cosmic order through the rhythm of stone. The war horse thus becomes more than a martial image—it embodies the disciplined energy of the state, the structured strength that sustains governance. Through this adaptation, the Constitution situates its vision of federal balance within India's ancient aesthetic of harmony between power and purpose, reminding the reader that strength achieves meaning only

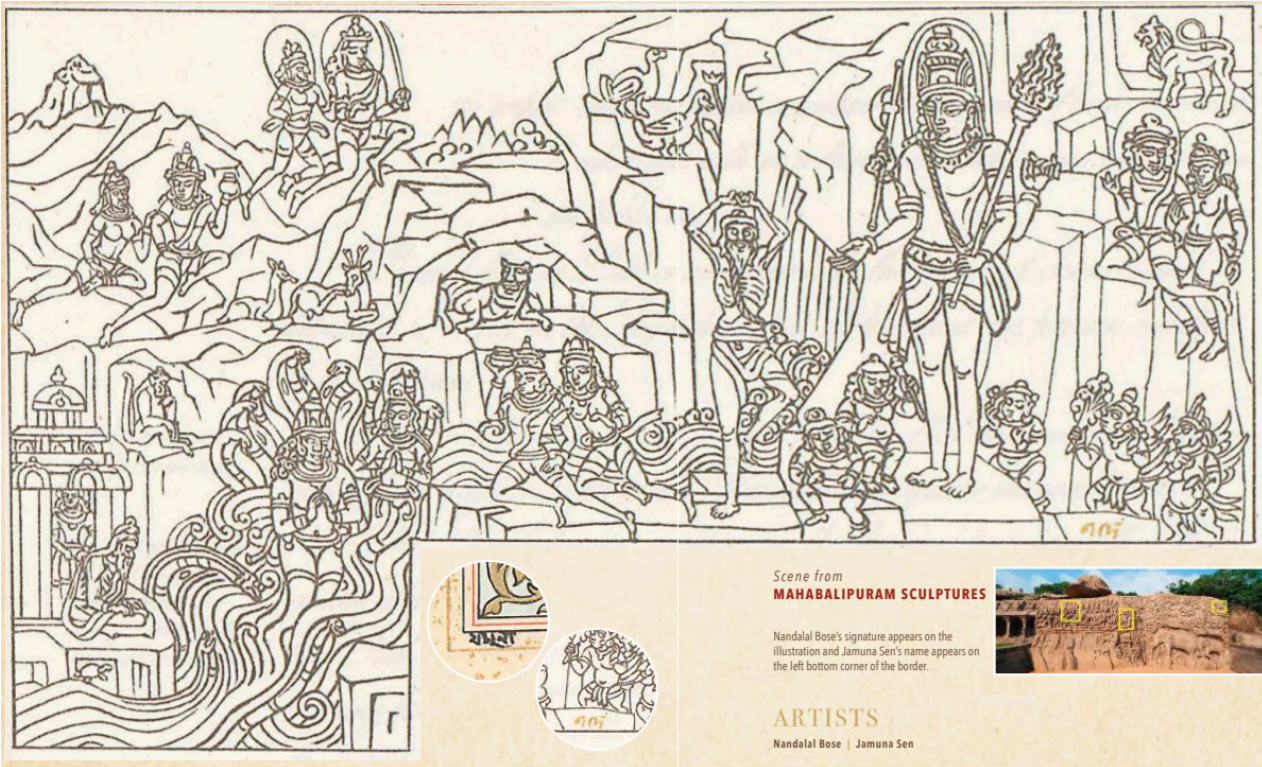
through control and cooperation.



This illustration inaugurates **Part XII of the Constitution, which concerns Finance, Property, Contracts, and Suits**, through a profound invocation of divine rhythm and universal law. At its centre stands Shiva as *Nataraja*, the cosmic dancer whose movement embodies the pulse of creation and the stillness of dissolution. Enclosed within a flaming aureole, Shiva's form unites grace with geometry—each limb balanced between repose and energy, each gesture resonant with metaphysical meaning. The figure's lifted leg and poised arms mark the dance of the cosmos itself: a choreography of creation, preservation, destruction, concealment, and grace, known in the *Shilpa-Shastras* as *Panchakritya*.

Rendered in the manner of the Chola bronzes of South India—particularly those from Chidambaram, the sacred seat of Nataraja worship—this composition is both devotional and philosophical. The drum in his upper hand signifies the birth of sound and time; the flame in the other marks the dissolution of form; the raised hand in *abhaya mudra* grants protection and dispels fear, while the foot pressed on the demon of ignorance (*Apasmara*) represents the grounding of the spirit in truth. The lifted foot, pointing upward, offers liberation to those who seek it. **Gouri Bhanja's** linear translation of the bronze into two dimensions preserves the sculpture's vitality while highlighting the quiet symmetry of its design—the arch of fire looping gracefully around the god's rhythmic motion. Her signature appears discreetly at the lower left corner, an acknowledgement of authorship without disturbing the divine centrality of the scene.

Placed at the opening of Part XII, the image reads as a meditation on order, wealth, and ethical motion. Just as Shiva's dance sustains the universe through balance and control, the financial and contractual provisions of the Constitution seek to maintain equilibrium between the spiritual and material life of the nation. The *abhayamudra*, offering assurance and benevolence, mirrors the state's obligation to safeguard fairness and justice within the flow of economic life. The entire visual serves as a reminder that governance, like cosmic rhythm, depends on measured motion—an interplay between power and restraint, continuity and change. By invoking Nataraja at this constitutional juncture, the framers and artists aligned India's legal and fiscal framework with one of its most enduring metaphors of harmony: the divine dance where energy and law become one.



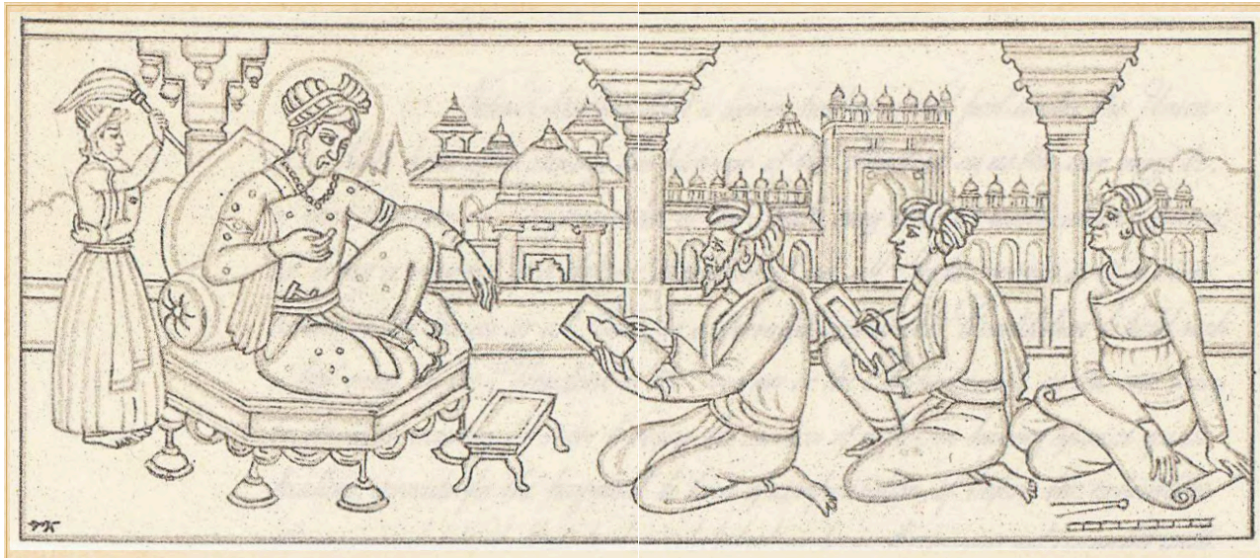
This illustration introduces **Part XIII of the Constitution, which concerns Trade, Commerce, and Intercourse within the Territory of India**, through an interpretation of one of India's most monumental sculptural narratives—the *Descent of the Ganges* relief at Mahabalipuram. Carved into a granite cliff on the Coromandel coast, the original composition depicts gods, ascetics, and animals witnessing the descent of the celestial river, released from heaven to nourish the earth. In this drawing, **Nandalal Bose and Jamuna Sen** reimagine that ancient scene with clarity and reverence. At the centre stands Lord Shiva, calm and monumental, receiving the torrent of the Ganges in his matted locks to soften its fall. Around him, divine beings and earthly creatures fill the landscape, their forms woven together by flowing lines that suggest both the motion of water and the movement of life.

Every figure in the composition contributes to the sense of collective participation—the hermits in meditation, the celestial beings hovering above, and the animals below that turn their heads in awe. The architectural backdrop evokes the rugged sanctuaries of South India, where nature and artistry blend seamlessly. The scene is a meditation on the idea of controlled flow: the Ganges must descend, but it must do so through moderation, channelled by divine wisdom.

In the constitutional context, this symbolism acquires striking relevance. Part XIII safeguards the free movement of trade and communication across India's diverse territories—ensuring that economic life flows freely, yet within the channels of law. Just as Shiva tempers the celestial river to make it life-giving rather than destructive, the Constitution directs the nation's commercial energies toward collective prosperity rather than chaos. Artistically, the work exemplifies Bose's disciplined linearity and Sen's fine sensitivity to contour. Their names, placed quietly along the border, reflect a shared authorship rooted in mentorship and collaboration—a hallmark of the Constitution's artistic project.

By evoking Mahabalipuram, a UNESCO World Heritage site where myth, nature, and craftsmanship converge, the illustration situates modern India's vision of economic unity within its ancient tradition of harmony between force and form. The Ganges here becomes more than a river—it becomes a metaphor

for circulation, connection, and renewal. In choosing this image, the Constitution reminds us that commerce, like the descent of the sacred river, must be free but not unrestrained—governed by balance, infused with purpose, and guided by the moral flow of dharma.



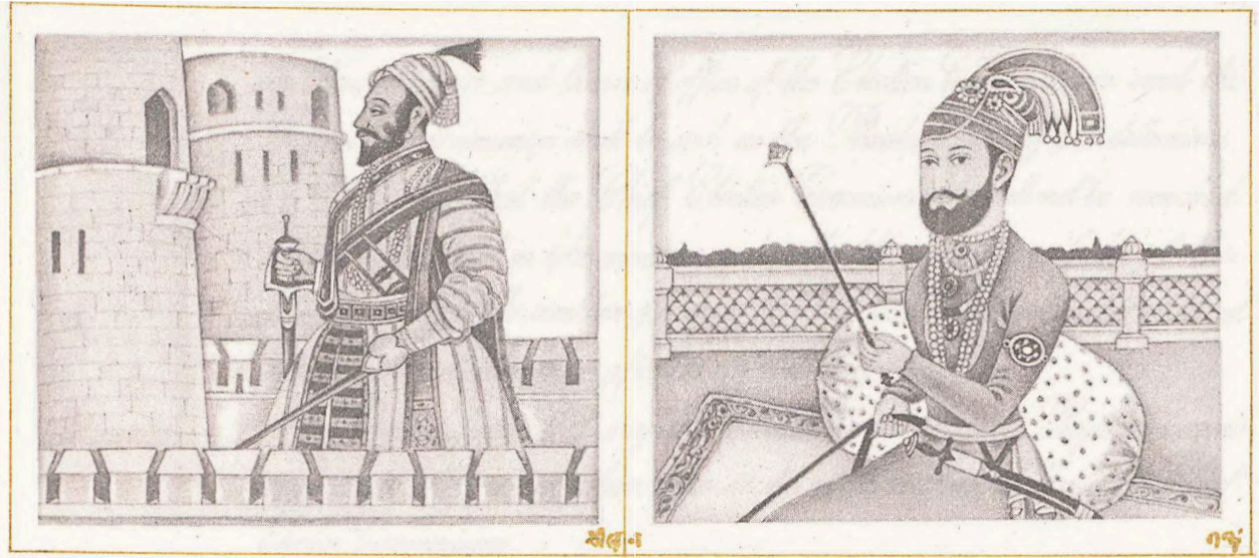
This illustration introduces **Part XIV of the Constitution**, which focuses on Services under the Union and the States, through a scene of regal deliberation drawn from the Mughal court of Emperor Akbar. The emperor, seated on a low throne with a bolster at his side, gestures in thoughtful engagement as scholars kneel before him, their manuscripts unfurled. Behind the emperor stands an attendant with a *chauri*, a fly whisk—a subtle emblem of decorum, hierarchy, and service. In the background, the elegant symmetry of Mughal architecture rises in soft perspective: bulbous domes, scalloped arches, and ornate gateways suggest the ordered grandeur of the imperial court.

The composition is not merely historical; it is allegorical. Akbar's court was famed as a centre of learning, tolerance, and governance grounded in dialogue. The emperor's posture—neither aloof nor authoritarian—embodies reasoned authority, while the scholars' attentive engagement reflects the spirit of collective deliberation. The image thus transforms a historical moment into a meditation on public service and intellectual exchange. It positions administration not as mechanical obedience, but as a moral and intellectual enterprise—one requiring balance between duty, reflection, and compassion.

In its constitutional placement, this scene resonates deeply with the ideals of Part XIV. Just as Akbar's courtiers served through counsel and knowledge, the civil services envisioned by the Constitution are meant to serve the state through integrity, discipline, and reason. The act of writing and consultation shown here becomes a metaphor for institutional learning and record-keeping—the foundations of governance. The calm spatial rhythm of the scene mirrors the constitutional vision of a bureaucracy that functions with precision and dignity, guided by wisdom rather than force.

Artistically, the piece bears the hallmarks of both **Nandalal Bose and Gouri Bhanja**. Bose's structural clarity shapes the architectural frame and the measured spatial composition, while Bhanja's fine linework brings subtle animation to the faces and textiles. Their signatures—Bose's within the main illustration and Bhanja's along the border—speak to this creative partnership that defined the visual language of the Constitution.

By invoking Akbar's court, the illustration situates modern India's administrative ideal within a lineage of enlightened statecraft. The emperor, remembered for his openness to knowledge and faith, becomes a timeless emblem of rational governance—an image that ties historical inclusiveness to the constitutional ethos of service. In this sense, the illustration transforms the Mughal durbar into a symbol of the Republic's own civil vision: authority guided by reason, power moderated by learning, and governance animated by the pursuit of collective good.



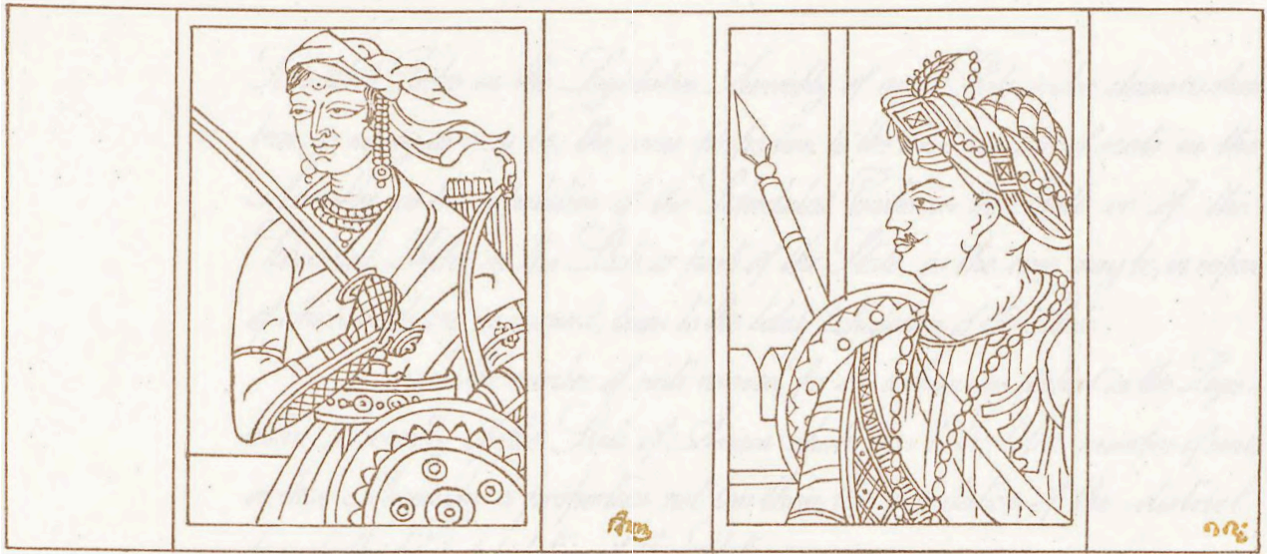
The opening of **Part XV of the Constitution, devoted to Elections**, is graced by the presence of two of India's most venerated leaders—**Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj** and **Guru Gobind Singh**—figures whose vision of governance was inseparable from justice, faith, and moral courage. Their portraits, conceived by **Dhirendra Krishna Deb Barman** and **Nandalal Bose**, are poised in dignified contrast: the Maratha sovereign surveying his fort, and the Sikh Guru enthroned in quiet authority. Together, they embody the twin foundations of leadership—strategic resolve and spiritual integrity.

On the left, Shivaji stands against the backdrop of formidable bastions and watchtowers, his hand resting lightly on his sword. His expression carries the calm confidence of a ruler who built not an empire of conquest but of consent and reform. The fort architecture rises like a metaphor for civic strength—each stone recalling his just administration, protection of subjects, and defence of self-rule (*swarajya*). The precision of the linework captures his energy without ornament, emphasising purpose over power.

Opposite him, Guru Gobind Singh sits composed yet unyielding, adorned with regal grace and symbols of divine authority. The staff in his hand becomes both sceptre and spiritual emblem—an extension of his resolve to unite devotion and discipline through the founding of the Khalsa. His layered necklaces and plume signify dignity, not splendour; his gaze suggests a deep inwardness beneath the warrior's calm.

Placed at the beginning of Part XV, this visual pairing bridges two epochs of struggle and statecraft, each grounded in ethical responsibility. Elections, as envisioned in the Constitution, rest upon the same ideals these leaders upheld: moral leadership, equality of purpose, and accountability to the people. The clean, harmonious composition—framed by Kripal Singh Shekhawat's border design—translates these ideals into visual order. It reminds the reader that the act of voting, too, is an act of faith: a peaceful renewal of

power that traces its lineage to the courage and conscience embodied by these sons of India.



Part XVI, which outlines Special Provisions for Certain Classes, opens with portraits of two warriors whose defiance against colonial rule became early testaments to India's unbroken spirit—**Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi** and **Tipu Sultan of Mysore**. Rendered in clear, disciplined lines by **Nandalal Bose and his son Biswarup Bose**, these figures transcend biography to become symbols of resistance, dignity, and the enduring quest for justice.

On the left, Rani Lakshmibai is depicted mid-motion, her face composed in strength and resolve. The sweep of her sword and the curve of her shield create a rhythm of poised energy, while her attire—simple yet commanding—anchors her in the Indian landscape of courage. Her expression holds neither fear nor fury, but steadfast clarity, recalling the moment when she led her troops into battle not for conquest, but for the defence of honour and homeland.

Facing her is Tipu Sultan, the *Sher-e-Mysore*, his profile noble and assured. His bejewelled turban and spear symbolise both royalty and resistance. The measured confidence in his gaze evokes the statesman-warrior who sought to preserve his kingdom's independence against overwhelming odds, uniting technological foresight with political conviction. His posture, firm and reflective, captures the composure of a man who stood for freedom as an act of destiny.

Together, these portraits speak to the Constitution's deeper moral foundation: its promise to protect those who have struggled, sacrificed, and suffered in the name of justice. In a section concerned with safeguarding the rights of the marginalised, their inclusion reminds us that courage, too, is a form of representation. The sparse linear style, characteristic of Bose's school, translates grandeur into grace—suggesting that dignity resides not in decoration but in conviction. At the threshold of Part XVI, Lakshmibai and Tipu stand as sentinels of constitutional empathy, linking past struggles with the ongoing pursuit of equality in independent India.



Part XVII, devoted to the Official Languages of India, begins with one of the most iconic images in the nation's visual history—**Bapuji**, Nandalal Bose's linocut portrait of Mahatma Gandhi during the Dandi March of 1930. The simplicity of the artwork belies its depth; in the unbroken sweep of its lines resides the full moral gravity of the Indian freedom struggle.

Gandhi is shown mid-step, draped in his plain *dhoti* and *chadar*, a walking stick in his right hand, guiding his steady progress. His posture is slightly bent, the curve of his back suggesting both physical frailty and spiritual strength. There is no background, no ornament, no distraction—only the solitary figure moving forward, embodying the essence of resolve. The economy of line and absence of embellishment reflect Gandhi's own ideals of restraint and truth. Every stroke seems to echo his philosophy of *ahimsa*: clarity of purpose, purity of means.

Created mere days after the conclusion of the Salt March, the image distills into visual form the spiritual rhythm of that journey—a movement not of rebellion but of awakening. As Gandhi marched to the sea to challenge the British salt monopoly, he transformed a humble mineral into a symbol of human dignity. In Bose's rendering, that act of defiance becomes timeless: Gandhi's step is every citizen's step toward freedom.

Its placement at the beginning of Part XVII is profoundly apt. Just as Gandhi reclaimed salt as the language of protest, this Part reclaims the many tongues of India as instruments of unity, self-expression, and belonging. The border designed by Bani Patel frames the composition in quiet reverence, its simplicity complementing the moral precision of Bose's lines. In this portrait, the Constitution acknowledges its deepest inheritance—the belief that true power lies in humility, that progress is a collective march, and that freedom, once awakened, must continue to speak in every voice of the nation.

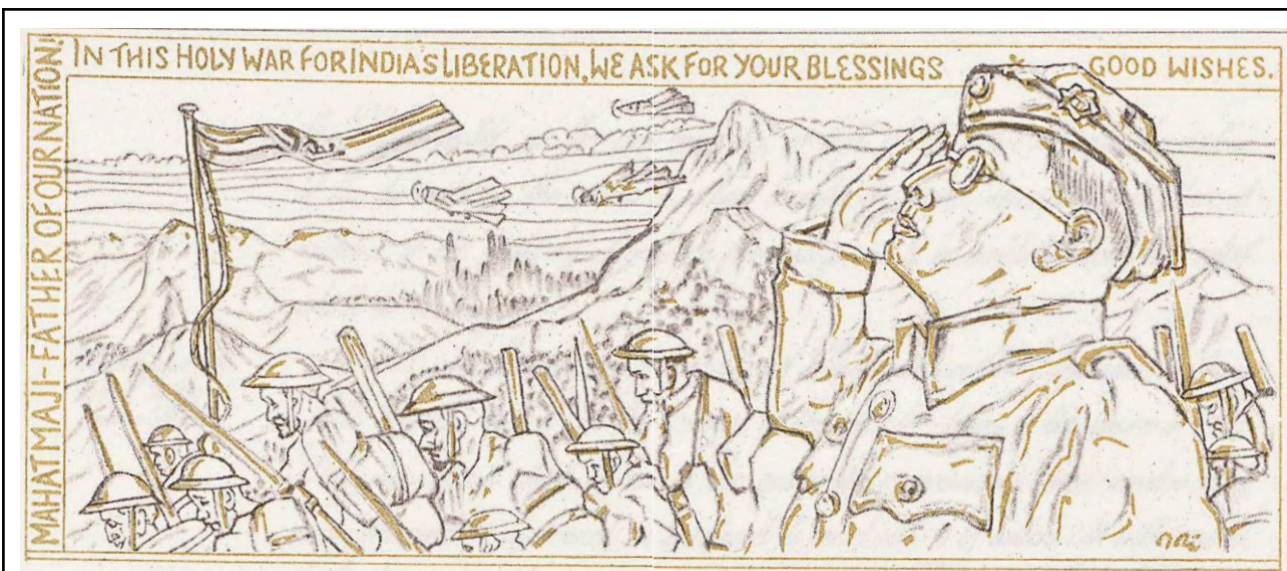


This illustration, introducing **Part XVIII of the Constitution**, which concerns **Emergency Provisions**, draws upon one of the most poignant episodes in India's struggle for moral restoration — Mahatma Gandhi's visit to Noakhali. Rendered by **Nandalal Bose**, with border design by **V. S. Masoji**, the composition embodies Gandhi not as a political leader but as a healer and peace-maker walking amid devastation. The scene captures him stepping across a bamboo bridge, frail yet resolute, his staff grounding him as he reaches out to those scarred by conflict. In front of him, a woman performs a ritual welcome with an oil lamp and a mark of reverence on his forehead — a gesture of devotion that transforms the act of greeting into one of purification and renewal. Around them, villagers stand with folded hands, their faces touched by humility and hope, while the palm-lined huts in the background quietly reassert the ordinariness of rural life that Gandhi sought to redeem.

The image's significance lies in its evocation of Gandhi's spiritual approach to crisis — the belief that peace could not be legislated or enforced, but had to be lived and embodied. Following the traumatic communal violence in Bengal, Gandhi's long walks through the villages of Noakhali were not political campaigns but acts of moral repair. In placing this moment at the opening of Part XVIII, the Constitution visually frames the idea of "emergency" not merely as a legal condition but as a test of national conscience. Just as Gandhi entered spaces torn by hatred with faith in reconciliation, the constitutional framework for emergencies carries the same tension — between authority and restraint, between order and compassion.

Artistically, Nandalal Bose's line work is austere, eschewing ornament for clarity of form. The figures are bound by simplicity and grace, their outlines rhythmic yet firm, a hallmark of the Santiniketan style that privileged emotional truth over decorative flourish. The linear balance between movement and stillness captures Gandhi's paradoxical presence — frail in body, yet immense in moral force. The woman's outstretched arm, the villagers' gestures, and the receding huts all draw the eye toward Gandhi's bowed head, the still centre of the composition.

By invoking this moment of peace-making, the illustration situates India's constitutional response to crises within the moral universe that Gandhi helped define. It reminds the reader that law and power, when tested by violence, must ultimately return to the same ground he walked — that of conscience, humility, and human connection.



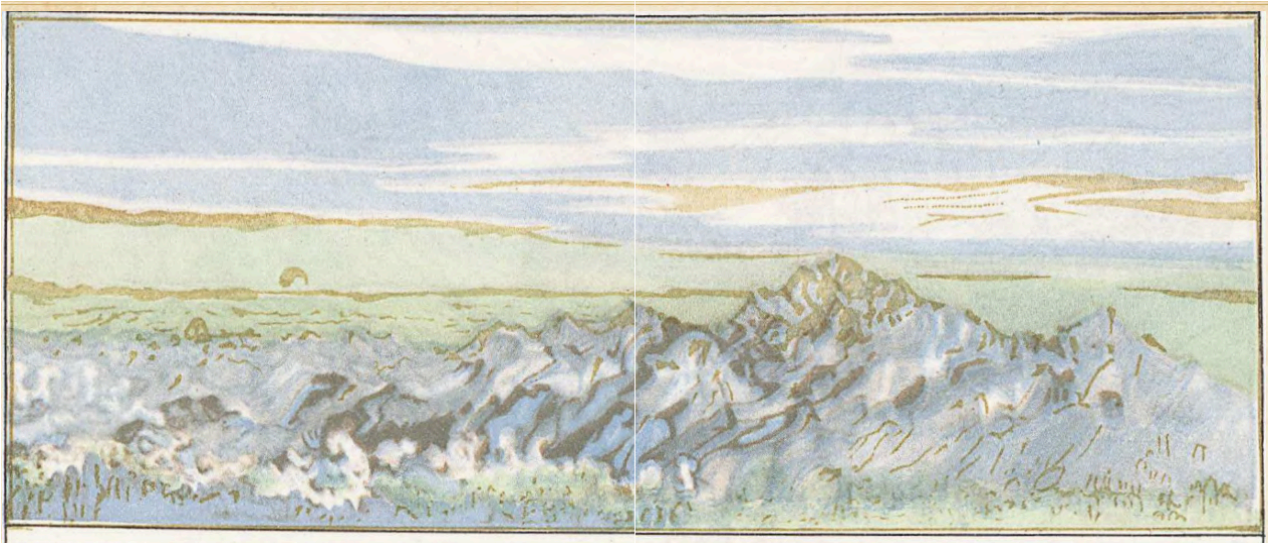
Introducing **Part XIX of the Constitution**, which gathers its **Miscellaneous Provisions**, this stirring composition honours Subhas Chandra Bose as the embodiment of militant patriotism and sacrifice. Designed by **Nandalal Bose, with A. Perumal's** signature at the base, the image portrays Netaji in full military attire, saluting against a dramatic landscape alive with movement and determination. Behind him, ranks of the Indian National Army (INA) march forward in disciplined formation, their bayonets raised and banners streaming against the mountain horizon. Overhead, aircraft sweep across the sky, echoing the martial rhythm of the troops below. At the upper border, an inscription invokes Gandhi: “Mahatmaji—Father of our Nation! In this holy war for India’s liberation, we ask for your blessings and good wishes.” The juxtaposition of Netaji’s salute and the invocation of Gandhi’s name fuses two distinct but converging visions of India’s freedom — one of moral resistance, the other of armed struggle.

The composition’s power lies in its synthesis of idealism and defiance. Bose, who resigned from the Indian Civil Service to join the national movement, symbolised a generation unwilling to accept passive endurance under colonial rule. In placing his image here, the Constitution pays tribute not only to his leadership of the Azad Hind Fauj but also to his unyielding belief that freedom required courage in every form. The mountainous terrain in the backdrop, with its upward sweep and vast horizon, mirrors the monumental scale of his ambition — a liberation that spanned continents and demanded unity in action.

Stylistically, the illustration reflects Nandalal Bose’s mastery of monumental simplicity. The clean lines, restrained palette, and sculptural solidity of the figures convey both discipline and vision. The rhythmic repetition of helmets and rifles gives the composition a forward momentum, while Netaji’s saluting figure anchors it in purpose. There is no spectacle of violence here — only the solemn dignity of soldiers bound by a moral cause.

Placed at the opening of Part XIX, the image assumes a symbolic closure to the constitutional narrative: from Gandhi’s peace-making to Bose’s defiant charge, the two consecutive illustrations represent the spectrum of India’s freedom struggle — conscience and courage, prayer and action. In immortalising them both, the Constitution situates its final provisions within a continuum of sacrifice and aspiration, reminding the reader that national law, like national freedom, was forged through both moral vision and

fearless resolve.



This serene landscape introduces **Part XX of the Constitution, which addresses the Amendment of the Constitution**, through a panoramic vision of the Himalayas—the eternal backbone of the Indian subcontinent. Painted by A. Perumal, the composition unfolds as a sweeping expanse of light, air, and form, where the ridged blue-grey peaks rise like frozen waves beneath a luminous sky. The sun glows faintly on the horizon, diffusing soft tones of gold and green across the distant plains, while streaks of cloud stretch horizontally, echoing the calm rhythm of continuity. The palette—dominated by cool blues and muted pastels—imbues the scene with an atmosphere of quiet majesty, suggesting endurance rather than drama.

Artistically, Perumal's rendering is minimalist yet deeply meditative. There are no human figures, no symbols of civilisation—only the vastness of nature in its unbroken equilibrium. The Himalayas here are not simply mountains; they are a metaphor for permanence and resilience, the ancient guardians that have watched over the subcontinent through epochs of change. The subtle gradations of light evoke both time and transformation, suggesting that even in stillness, evolution persists.

Placed before Part XX, this image carries a profound constitutional resonance. The Himalayas, with their timeless solidity, parallel the enduring framework of the Constitution, while the play of light across their slopes alludes to the living, adaptive nature of constitutional amendment. Just as these ranges channel the great rivers—the Ganges, Indus, and Brahmaputra—that nourish the land, the Constitution channels the currents of national will and renewal. Through this visual metaphor, the illustration unites nature's permanence with the vitality of human law, reminding us that strength and flexibility together sustain the life of a nation.



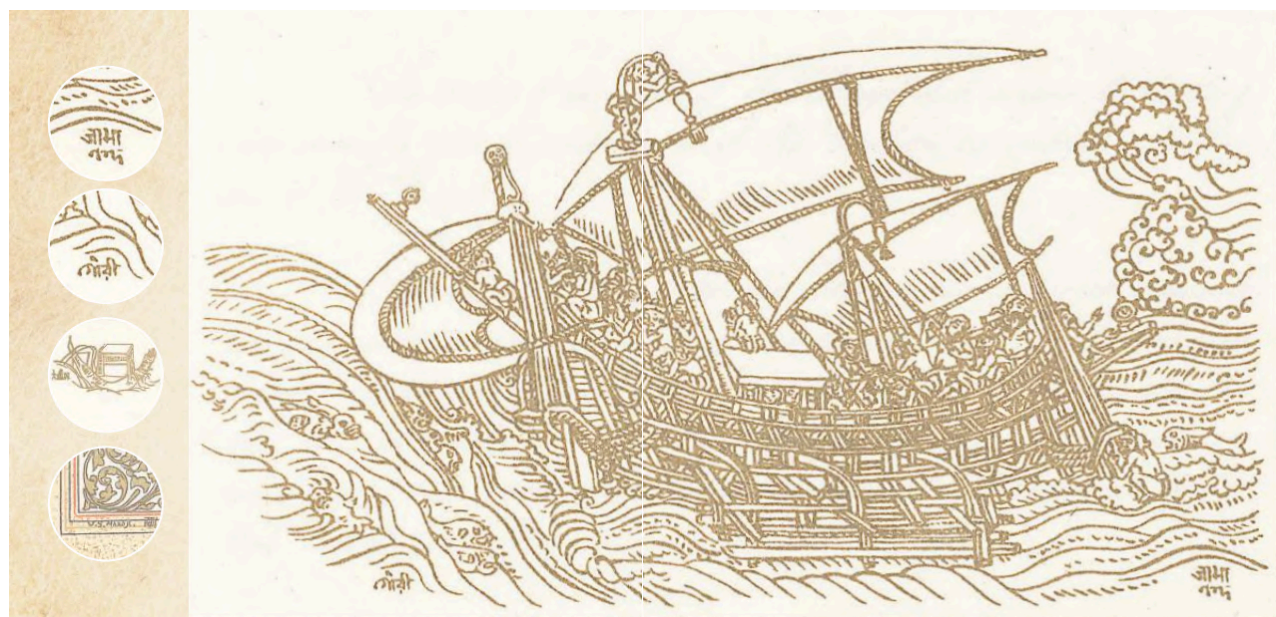
Introducing **Part XXI of the Constitution**, which brings together its *Temporary and Transitional Provisions*, this sweeping composition by **Nandalal Bose** unfolds as a visual parable of endurance, continuity, and movement through change. Bearing the signatures of **Nivedita Bose**, **Biswarup Bose**, and **Nandalal Bose** himself, the artwork depicts a long caravan crossing an expanse of mountainous desert — a land of transition, symbolic of India’s passage from colonial bondage to sovereign statehood.

At the heart of the image, a dignified nobleman rides high upon a camel, the fabled “ship of the desert,” his bearing calm and resolute beneath a streaming crest that announces both rank and purpose. Around him, attendants and traders guide their animals laden with goods, their silhouettes forming a rhythmic procession that winds through undulating ridges. The distant horizon is marked by faint outlines of more travellers, their forms merging with the landscape, suggesting the continuity of generations and the timelessness of the journey.

This is not merely a depiction of a desert crossing; it is an allegory for a nation in transit — poised between the past and the future, between empire and independence. The camels, steady and enduring, represent resilience; the banners fluttering in the wind stand for direction and governance; and the winding path evokes the long and arduous road toward national unity. In its compositional symmetry and measured movement, the image mirrors the transitional provisions it accompanies — those legal bridges that allowed India to move with balance and deliberation from a colonial framework to a democratic order.

Stylistically, the work reflects Bose’s mastery of *monumental simplicity*: every line is purposeful, every curve dignified. The figures are sculptural in their stillness, yet the entire composition hums with silent motion. The fine linear drawing, rendered in warm sepia tones, suggests both the parched austerity of the desert and the inner discipline of those who traverse it. The absence of excess detail focuses attention on essence — the quiet majesty of progress through perseverance.

Placed at this pivotal juncture of the Constitution, *The Desert* stands as a meditation on transition — a reminder that freedom is not merely a destination but a journey sustained by endurance, cooperation, and faith. It honours those who carried the nation through its most uncertain passages, ensuring that every step, like the imprint of a camel’s foot in sand, moved steadily toward a horizon of self-rule and renewal.



Concluding the great manuscript with **Part XXII of the Constitution**, titled *Short Title, Commencement and Repeals*, this commanding composition by **Nandalal Bose** and his collaborators — **Gouri Bhanja, Jabha, and V. S. Masoji** — turns the viewer's gaze to the open sea, where a grand vessel rides the tumultuous waves. It is an image both literal and symbolic: a ship of civilisation, propelled by human effort and divine wind, charting a course through the vast ocean of time.

The central ship, constructed in an ancient maritime form, is shown heaving against a restless tide. Its ribbed framework and billowing sails recall the great seafaring traditions of early India — from the merchants of the Indus to the explorers of the Indian Ocean. The deck is alive with figures: sailors at the oars, navigators at the helm, commanders at the prow, their gestures unified in purpose. Around them, the waters rise and swirl, carved into rhythmic patterns that evoke both danger and dynamism. To one side, the curling waves form motifs of fish and foam, echoing the natural abundance and the unpredictability of the sea.

In constitutional symbolism, *The Ocean* represents commencement — the launch of a voyage into independence. Just as ancient mariners once connected India to distant continents through trade and cultural exchange, so too does the Constitution link a diverse people through the unifying current of law and governance. The ship becomes a metaphor for the Republic itself: a vessel built from collective labour, navigating through untested waters with courage as its compass and justice as its sail.

The multiple signatures inscribed upon the artwork — in Bengali, Hindi, and English — mirror the multilingual, plural spirit of the nation. Each name represents a voice within a chorus, much like the varied regions and traditions united under one constitutional framework. Together, they affirm that India's journey forward would not rest upon a single hand but upon the coordinated strength of many.

Visually, Bose's composition captures the elemental force of motion. The sea is rendered not as chaos but as rhythm — a living texture of energy that challenges and uplifts. The ship's structure, firm yet flexible, embodies the Constitution's essence: resilient in principle, adaptable in practice. The contrast of vertical masts and sweeping waves creates a visual dialogue between stability and change, echoing the balance between continuity and reform that defines India's democratic foundation.

As the final image in the illustrated Constitution, *The Ocean* does more than close the document; it

propels it forward. It transforms the act of constitutional commencement into a spiritual and historical voyage — one that continues beyond the written word, into the living current of the nation's future. Here, at the meeting of law and art, the Republic sets sail, its course charted by centuries of heritage and the boundless horizon of freedom.

What the Constitution conveys through its Illustrations: An analysis

The illustrated manuscript of the **Constitution of India** stands as one of the most remarkable fusions of art, philosophy, and statecraft in modern history. Conceived under the artistic direction of **Nandalal Bose** and executed by a collective of artists from **Kala Bhavana, Santiniketan**, the visual programme transforms a legal document into a cultural artefact of profound symbolic and aesthetic significance. Each illustration extends the textual ideals of the Constitution into a visual dialogue between governance and moral imagination. The sequence of images unfolds as a civilisational journey, beginning with the seals of the Indus Valley and the Vedic ashrams of learning, continuing through the teachings of the Buddha and Mahavira, and culminating in the modern moral exemplars of Gandhi and Subhas Chandra Bose. Together, these scenes trace the evolution of India's collective conscience and intellectual heritage. The visual narrative situates the Constitution within a continuum of history and philosophy, reminding the viewer that the Indian Republic emerged not from rupture, but from renewal within a long tradition of ethical, cultural, and spiritual reflection.

At its core, the Constitution's visual language is not decorative but didactic. Each image interprets the principles of the text through familiar moral and cultural symbols. The section on **Fundamental Rights**, for instance, is introduced by a scene from the *Ramayana*, where Ram, Sita, and Lakshman embody righteousness, justice, and restraint. These values form the ethical foundation upon which civic freedoms depend. Similarly, the depiction of **Krishna counselling Arjuna** at the opening of the *Directive Principles of State Policy* reimagines a philosophical dialogue as a constitutional metaphor. The State, like Arjuna, must act not from impulse or desire, but from discernment and duty. In this way, the illustrations transform the Constitution into a moral and spiritual text that articulates governance as an ethical enterprise. Through the language of India's classical traditions, the manuscript asserts that freedom and responsibility, rights and duties, are inseparable. The result is a visual philosophy that unites the ancient pursuit of dharma with the modern pursuit of justice.

Equally significant is the collective nature of the artistic enterprise, which mirrors the democratic ethos that the Constitution itself enshrines. Although **Nandalal Bose** served as the guiding visionary, the project brought together artists such as **Beohar Rammanohar Sinha, Jamuna Sen, Gouri Bhanja, Dinanath Bhargava**, and **V. S. Masoji**, among others, each contributing distinctive strengths to a shared aesthetic vision. The collaborative process reflected the spirit of Santiniketan's pedagogy, where individual creativity flourished within a framework of community and mutual respect. Drawing on diverse regional and historical influences such as Ajanta's murals, Orissan sculpture, Mughal painting, and Chola bronzes, the artists created a unified visual language that celebrated plurality as a foundation of identity. The use of signatures in several scripts, including Bengali, Hindi, and English, symbolises the multilingual and multicultural unity of the nation. The manuscript thus becomes a microcosm of the Republic itself, a federation of forms and voices that combine to produce harmony through diversity. It embodies Bose's vision of contextual modernism, which sought to root artistic expression in indigenous tradition while addressing the moral and intellectual challenges of modernity.

The Constitution's illustrations ultimately convey a deeper understanding of the relationship between culture and law. By embedding the founding legal text within a framework of visual symbolism, the framers and artists articulated an idea of the Republic as a moral civilisation as much as a political entity. The sequence of images featuring Gandhi's Dandi March, his visit to Noakhali, Netaji's salute, and the serene Himalayan landscape reflects a spectrum of national ideals that range from peace and humility to courage and endurance. The concluding compositions, *The Desert* and *The Ocean*, transform the transitional and closing provisions into metaphors of journey and renewal, suggesting that constitutional life, like nature itself, is continuous and evolving. In this synthesis of art, ethics, and governance, the Constitution transcends its legal function to become a visual scripture of democracy. It embodies the Indian ideal that true unity arises from diversity, and that the strength of a nation lies as much in its moral vision as in its laws.
